The Sound of Silence

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/62459467.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Sensory Deprivation, frienemies to lovers, Falling In Love, Angst, Slice of Life, Fluff, a bit of comedy, Slow Burn-ish, poor Phainon needs a hug, Mydei tries not to lose his shit, Eventual Smut, top!Mydei, needy bottom!Phainon, Sexual Tension, Masturbation, Rimming, FaceFucking, Creampies

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-01-24 Completed: 2025-03-27 Words: 28,707 Chapters: 11/11

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Summary

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>
> “What a situation,” Aglaea laments.
>
> “I wonder who will help him,” is Trinnon’s two cents.
>
> “Now’s your cue, De,” Trianne whispers at him from in between her tiny hands, like it wasn't damn obvious his fate was sealed the moment they all looked at him.
>
> “Splendid idea. Leave it to the homicidal maniac to be his caretaker; what could possibly go wrong?”

Alternatively: A cursed Phainon can't speak, see or hear. Mydei is tasked with taking care of him until everything's sorted out.

Notes

Hello hi? Hi! I'm nervous af hnnnnngh (´⊙ω⊙`)！ Haven't written in probably a year, couldn't even finish the main 3.0 quest yet and I'M ALREADY NECK DEEP IN THIS DAMN PAIRING. Still trying my best to make stuff as accurate as possible, I swear.

Sorry for, like, something.

What am I apologizing for? I don't fucking know.

I'll (hopefully) see you at the bottom! ✧\(^w^;)ﾉ✧

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Mydei isn’t sure how to feel when Tribbie tells him the grim news.

First, in all honesty and completely disregarding Tribbie’s tearful expression, he takes it as a joke – Phainon, injured? Worse yet, *cursed* – can’t speak, see or hear? Such a tasteless prank. That would mean he *lost* to someone – someone who isn’t Mydei – or, at the very least, let his guard down enough to be in trouble. That’s unbelievable on its own, but… unless this is some sort of fucked up, terrible joke…

Mydei is to blame.

He was supposed to head out together with Phainon on a hunt, but they had a fallout the day before – one so stupid and unnecessary that he wonders how it escalated or why it even happened in the first place. It’s as normal as breathing for them to quarrel, but it’s the first time that Mydei felt the bitter taste of *venom* on his tongue.

The scene replays brokenly, blurrily in his mind – his fingers curling around the front of Phainon’s clothes to pull him close in anger; retribution in the form of a rebellious headbutt. He remembers the heat of their foreheads pressed together and the icy blue of Phainon’s eyes slanted in irritation; he remembers how low their voices went as they exchanged insults that got heavier and harsher.

In the end, Phainon pushed him out of his way and hissed *"I can do this on my own"* between gritted teeth, leaving immediately after.

Mydeimos let him.

If I were there with you—

"Lil' De, please come with us," the small redhead attempts, pulling him by the sash to gain his attention, "Snowy doesn't let anyone touch him, or even get close. We're so worried… we don't know what to do…!"

He has so many questions. So many doubts and regrets, and so much *anger* about the whole situation.

The one thing he doesn't have is hesitation.

He opens his eyes to see Phainon's form, one knee on the ground and the other leg bent. His broadsword's upright, the tip sunken into the earth and the handle gripped tightly by the Deliverer. He's curled over himself beside the weapon with his head cast down, silver hair covering his face and lightly swaying with the chilly air floating around, a cold pocket dimension

with its own atmosphere. Titankin corpses surround the immediate area, blood bathing the grass and turning it red.

Although Mydei has never seen Phainon in this particular stance, it’s easy to see that he’s on the defensive – seems ready to slay any danger that he may perceive as soon as it's within range.

“He’s attacking anyone and anything that approaches,” a feminine voice explains from behind him, confirming his first impressions.

The kremnoan spins on his heel to look at the ladies – Aglaea with a hand to her chest in a display of worry, and the redhead triplets huddled together holding hands. “Including *you?”* he directs at the blonde.

“Unfortunately. I believe Tribbie has briefed you on the situation, no? Phainon has been cursed,” she reaffirms, “He’s lost his sight, his hearing and his voice.”

“How did any of this happen?”

“We're looking into it. There's not much information at the moment,” the blonde says with a tinge of regret. “You may be able to help with the immediate situation, though.”

“Mmhm. What do I do? Knock him out?” the kremnoan suggests with a glance at Phainon, absentmindedly counting the cuts visible over his clothes. How’d he get hurt, this idiot? Mydei resists the temptation to curl his fingers into angry fists, if only to fool himself that *it’s fine, this puppy-faced buffoon will be up and running in a moment.*

“Nooo, poor Snowy!” and “Could you please be careful with him, Mydeimos?” are his simultaneous replies.

“I was joking,” he sighs, “I’ll try to be gentle.”

After all… I'm partially to blame.

He takes the first step towards Phainon. Considers whether to fight, to *actually* punch some sense back into the Deliverer’s face, or to simply defend himself when Phainon inevitably lunges at him – if there's one thing that man will recognize even if all of his senses are lost, after all, it's Mydei's strength.

Two more steps, and the chill begins to bite at his naked skin. Phainon’s stance changes. His grip on his sword tightens, head slowly lifting up to show vacant eyes staring ahead and a golden cut on his cheek. He looks tired. How long has he been on full alert, killing everything that comes close? Ever since he left yesterday?

“Look at you,” Mydei breathes out, his hot breath forming vapor, “You're a mess.”

Another step into the icy realm, and Phainon stands up. Broadsword in hand, he readies himself for the offensive – speckles of snow lift off the grassy ground, the air getting thick and heavy with an inebriating blend of power and fear – he's a cornered beast, ready to defend himself to the last breath. Mydei unbuckles his right gauntlet, sighing; a white cloud escapes from behind his teeth.

“I thought,” he teases, “You said you could handle this on your own?”

Phainon dashes towards him, sword cutting horizontally through the chilly air. Mydei stops the blade with his remaining gauntlet, sparks flying with the deafening clash; he holds it in place without allowing his feet to move even an inch. Phainon stops moving immediately, glazed eyes widening, lips parting.

They silently form Mydei’s name.

The kremnoan swallows down, a lump forming in his throat. “Get well soon so I can properly apologize for this fuck-up,” he murmurs, his gloveless hand lifting up towards Phainon’s face, “I don't want to owe you *anything.* I'm sure the opposite is also true.” Mydei's thumb draws over the cut on his icy cheek, and with every inch he crosses, the Deliverer further relaxes and his sword further descends, until he finally allows it to fall from his grasp.

He releases a shaky breath, eyelids fluttering closed as he loses his balance. Mydei quickly catches him by the waist, holding him upright, but there's no doubt that he's unconscious.

“Welp,” he grimaces, “Looks like I *did* knock him out.”

“He's stable… just tired, I suppose,” Aglaea affirms as she walks out of Phainon’s room, “But he *will* need to be cared for, for as long as this curse persists.”

Mydei makes a point of not looking at *any* of them, yet he feels *all* the eyes in the room right on his face, and *hates* what it means. At least the mood feels light enough that it reassures him things will be alright – an invisible weight lifts off his shoulders, and for that he is thankful. Alas:

“Sooo…” Tribbie begins, soundly smacking her lips.

“What a situation,” Aglaea laments.

“I wonder who will help him,” is Trinnon’s two cents.

“Now’s your cue, De,” Trianne whispers at him from in between her tiny hands, like it wasn't damn obvious his fate was sealed the moment they all looked at him.

“Splendid idea. Leave it to the homicidal maniac to be his caretaker; what could *possibly* go wrong?”

Aglaea smiles, either because she doesn't follow his logic or – most likely – because she doesn't care. Maybe she knows something he doesn't; he wouldn't put it past her to have understood all that happened the moment she went into that room. “If I remember correctly, you're the one who was able to calm him down.”

“If you *don't* remember correctly, we can barely stand each other on a good day.” He sighs, pressing a hand to his forehead. “In what world is this a smart move? If there's anything else I can do to help, like *killing* something, I’ll gladly—”

There's a loud noise from the bedroom, followed by glass breaking. Aglaea and the triplets run immediately inside, while Mydei hesitates for a second – bites his lip, clicks his tongue, rubs his face – not exactly out of annoyance, but because he *knows* he can snap that big idiot out of whatever trance he's in, and *that* annoys him.

He walks in just in time to see Phainon sitting on the ground right against the bed, the wounds on his naked upper body covered in bandages and an arm folded in front of his face, as if to protect it. There's a broken vase right beside him. His eyes are wide and searching for things that he unfortunately cannot see, chest moving rapidly with shallow breaths – it's impossible to tell what exactly he's thinking, but it's evident that he's anxious. Hopefully it's not a full-blown panic attack.

“Snowy…!” Tribbie whines, her sisters holding her small body as she trembles. Did he push her away?

“Let me try,” Mydei grumbles, crossing the distance between them to flick Phainon on the forehead. The startled Deliverer flinches, eyes widening just like last time, as he mouths Mydei's name. He’s always looked like a puppy, but *this* is just… *unfair.*

With hesitation, the kremnoan lands a hand over a tense, cold shoulder. In response, Phainon's breathing visibly slows down – he sighs, tiredly rubbing at his eyes, his body steadily relaxing. Crisis averted.

Mydei, of course, groans as loud as he possibly can without sounding like a dromas.

“You're not helping my case *at all*, damn it!”

“I imagine that means you will help,” Aglaea chuckles. “Rest assured – we will offer all the assistance you need, as well as search for a way to end this curse as soon as possible. Now, would you rather stay in his home, or bring him to yours?”

I wish I never had to see your face again.

Phainon curls himself further over his folded legs, face buried into his folded arms. Where is he…? He doesn't know. It feels like a bed, but could be a couch or a folded cloth on the floor for all he knows. At the very least, he's *pretty* sure his back is against a wall – feels hard and cold.

Mydei… Mydei took him somewhere. Home?

I don't want to talk to you anymore. I don't want to hear your stupid voice.

His lips quiver with a mix of anger, sadness, frustration, *fear.* He's trapped in his own body – a prison of absolute darkness and cold silence. He doesn't know what time it is, where he is, if he's alone or not, or what's happening beyond this cage of flesh he's caught in. He's living in a limbo.

This isn't *at all* what he wanted.

He'd been so angry, so *furious* – his fight with Mydei left him raging. In an uncharacteristically aggressive way to release stress, Phainon left by himself to hunt down and slay as many enemies as he could, all while those thoughts played in his head like a mantra, consuming his being.

I hate…

That last thought, he couldn't complete.

Tired and covered in blood, Phainon crouched down and hung his head between his legs with a sigh – *I don't hate him,* he'd thought. He's just angry. He's just stupid. *They* are stupid.

By the time he calmed down, though, it was already too late – the moment he stood up and opened his eyes, his world had lost its axis.

Biting down on his lip hard enough to taste blood, Phainon runs a hand through his hair and grabs it tightly. The universe itself is against him and his anger towards Mydei, it seems. Will he ever even go back to normal? Is *this* – whatever *this* is – even curable?

He releases his hair and realizes that he's trembling. Phainon places his hand in front of his face and flexes his fingers, closes and opens his fist, yet sees nothing but darkness. He barely feels *real.* Maybe he's dreaming, or caught in an *actual* limbo. Maybe he's dying. Maybe he's already *dead—*

There's a hot spark on his fingertip – warm, calloused flesh; an unmistakable, all-consuming heat. *Mydei's hand.* Phainon's breath catches on his throat as that warmth spreads from the tips of his fingers down to his palm, and encases his trembling limb.

He's suddenly very *alive.* The sharp contrast in temperature makes him dizzy, the convergence of their skins becomes the center of his universe, the intense grip stops his world from frantically spinning. Mydei’s hold slowly slides down towards Phainon's wrist…

…and makes him slap himself on the face.

“...son of a…!”

He snorts – *unbelievable!* – and, within moments and against all odds, begins to laugh. He doesn't hear the sounds he's producing, but feels the vibrations of the joyful sounds on his ribs and in his throat. His eyes feel wet. He wipes at them and collects many more tears than he'd rather have shed.

This isn't just mirth.

He's afraid.

“Mydei,” he calls out in complete silence into the void, *“What have I done?”*

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Wowzers, thank you all SO MUCH for the feedback, holy shite!! ヽ(。> ˘ <)ノ♡
>
> I won't update this regularly as in... on a schedule, but I *will* update one or twice a week, so expect more updates soon! (〃> ᗜ <〃)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei stands in the middle of the living room with arms crossed over his chest and a scowl. The next time *anyone* dares call him a psychopath, he's forcing them to take a look at Phainon's house.

He’s just finished taking a tour of the whole place – better get used to the plane of existence he's stuck in for the foreseeable future – and struggled to find just *one* disorganized item. This so-called ‘home’ is almost *sterile.*

In a way, he's thankful for that – albeit excessive a configuration, this means Phainon must know exactly where he keeps his things at all times. Mydei opted to stay at the Deliverer's house exactly to make his lack of sight easier on him, after all; he's going to need *some* level of independence if either of them mean to come out of this with their sanity intact.

Now that Mydei’s finished putting his things away in the guest room, he returns to the titular owner of the place – opens the door to Phainon's bedroom only to find him in the exact position as he'd left him some half an hour, forty minutes ago.

Phainon is, by no means, a small guy – he's not as tall as Mydei, of course; there's probably one third of an inch of height difference between them, *really* – and his clothes do hide meat and muscle alike, but… he looks *tiny* on his bed. Not only is the furniture large by itself, the way Phainon hugs his legs close to his chest and rest his chin on top makes him appear…

Mydei doesn't want to say *vulnerable,* but that's exactly what it is.

Phainon's blue gaze stares ahead, sometimes drifting off to one side or the other, but always vacant, completely lost. Reminds him of Aglaea, but he's aware the comparison isn't exactly fair and the Deliverer's natural puppy looks don't really help. It doesn't take much to see that he's absolutely *miserable,* and Mydei would pity him and his situation if it wasn't a disservice to his person.

He's considering messing with Phainon just to draw some sort of reaction when there's a knock at the front door – must be Tribbie; she *did* say she'd hop by after they were settled to check on them.

Mydei opens the door to find the gleeful redhead holding a big paper bag – “Pancakes!” she announces, “Lil's De’s favorites!”

“Lively, aren't we,” he greets as he's stepping away for her to enter. He leads her to the dining room and fishes through the cabinets – which one was it again? – for cutlery, making a mental note of where they are just so he isn't so lost the next time. After setting them on the table, he turns towards Phainon's room. “I’ll go get the snowflake.”

He briefly stands by the doorway – the Deliverer hasn't moved an inch. Unsurprising, yet still disappointing; Mydei hasn't lost hope that this curse will magically lift itself any moment now, after which he'll promptly solicit a duel so they can punch their apologies into each other's faces.

He decides to approach. Sitting close to the Deliverer, one leg bent on the bed, he's not surprised to have Phainon tense up and frown at his immediate direction, no doubt gauging whether he's a threat or not.

“It’s Mydei,” he attempts, “Tribbie brought some food.”

As expected, there's no response nor any sign that Phainon may have heard him. The only clue that he's even aware that there's someone close by is the tension in his body – it shows on his shoulders, on the strain in his expression, on the whitening of his knuckles as he holds his legs tight.

Mydei can't help the sigh that he releases. He reaches out for Phainon's hand, keeping his eyes on the Deliverer's expression as he allows his fingertips to glide over those strained knuckles. Phainon's breath visibly hitches, his Adam's apple bobbing with a gulp. He does relax, yet his blue irises soon dart away and his lower lip slips into his mouth – if he's embarrassed or just disgruntled, Mydei can't tell.

“You’re under the care of the goddamned crown prince of Kremnos, you know,” he murmurs with a smirk, “No safer place in the world. Maybe start being less suspicious of your surroundings?”

It's easy to imagine what kind of reply Phainon would give him – *“I’d be safer pushing my head into a wasp’s nest”* or some such nonsense… only to, indeed, heed to Mydei's words and calm down until the whole ordeal ended.

They're always dancing around each other like that, aren't they? Always teasing, but also trusting; pushing each other's buttons just enough to weave some sweet, positively *delicious* adrenaline into their interactions. To completely shift that pleasant dynamic into *this.*.. is simply torture.

“...we should get some food in your system before you starve,” Mydei ultimately mutters, sliding his hand to Phainon's wrist to pull on it, then guiding him into standing up. “If the last sound I’m able to hear from you is your stomach rumbling, I swear on Nikador’s name I will commit a crime.”

Phainon briefly loses his balance as he stands up, but quickly gathers himself. The kremnoan takes his hand to avoid more accidents and begins a slow stride, always looking back to make sure the Deliverer can accompany his pace, which he *does.*.. more or less. There's a look of utmost concentration on his face, his lips pressed into a thin line, and he's evidently trying his best to make his unsteady steps seem confident.

Tribbie’s already devouring her pancakes by the time they arrive back in the dining room; she stops at the sight of them, her cheeks full, big eyes slowly lowering towards their joined hands. Mydei refuses to comment on anything – the curious look on her face is very telling of her thoughts – and leads Phainon to the table. He sets the Deliverer's hand on the back of one of the chairs, allowing him to feel around it and to sit down at his own pace.

Mydei sits down himself, in front of the remaining one of three stacks of pancakes Tribbie set down, and looks up just in time to see Phainon sink his hand right into the slimy syrup over the dessert. The Deliverer grimaces, saying – no doubt – an incredibly dirty choice word that unfortunately they cannot hear, and lifts his hand up, fingers parting while the golden concoction drips down, and his eye twitching.

“Poor Snowy,” Tribbie pouts, “Maybe you should feed him, De!”

“Maybe I should eat *all* of these pancakes and leave none to you two.”

The redhead gasps and shoves a large piece into her mouth, chewing at the speed of sound. Mydei shakes his head with a small smile and turns his attention to the sticky situation with Phainon – takes his wrist, careful not to get any syrup on his own fingers, and makes the confused Deliverer taste the mess he's made of his hand.

Phainon is fast to catch on to the situation, and proceeds to lick himself clean. Mydei makes a face – *I was going to hand you a napkin, stupid* – but decides against commenting on anything. Tribbie finishes her pancakes right about the time he's about to begins eating his own, which leaves her with *a lot* of free time to talk, which he should have known is a terrible, *terrible* thing.

“You’re surprisingly apt at this,” she comments, beginning the countdown to the full destruction of Mydei's brain cells.

“I'm aware a *certain someone* calls me a troglodyte,” he grumbles, scowling pointedly at Phainon, who manages to find his fork and knife… but not to use them very well, “But I'm nowhere near a mindless killing machine. I *do* have empathy.” Sometimes.

“Well, we *are* talking about Snowy, so I guess you're right.”

Mydei stops moving with his fork halfway to his mouth, eyebrows nearly connecting with a frown. “I beg your pardon?”

“Nothing!”

Lies. Tribbie smiles *big*, elbows setting over the table and her little hands joining under chin. The kremnoan is *almost* tempted to press her for more but ultimately decides against it, instead briefly glancing at Phainon – his pancakes seem to have been ravaged by war, bits and pieces strewn around the plate. There's syrup on his nose.

Mydei wants to end the poor snowflake’s misery with a napkin to the face, but Tribbie keeps watching him, judging his every move , and it makes him *mad.* He'll just push Phainon under the shower once she leaves.

“Lil' De,” she calls in a curious tone, “You know you didn't have to say *yes*, right?”

He pauses again. Feels the last bit of his brain juices being squeezed right out of his head.

“You and Aglaea—”

“No one would be able to force you to do this if you didn't want to. You know there were other options, other Chrysos Heirs. You *wanted* this,” she interrupts with a smile, “You wanted to help Lil’ Phai.”

Phainon stabs his pancakes.

For a moment, Mydei actually thinks he heard the whole spiel and has his senses back, ready to attempt murder – good riddance! – but his hopes are crushed the moment he sees a piece of the dessert stuck to the Deliverer's cheek, frustration darkening his gaze.

“Wow. And they call *me* barbaric.”

“What can I say,” Tribbie shrugs with a teensy smile, getting up to leave and no doubt leave the pancake warzone for Mydei to take care of, “Peas in a pod!”

Mydei sighs.

Note to self: give Phainon a spoon next time.

It's an all-out attack on his remaining senses – the sweet smell of vanilla and caramelized sugar, the texture of what he guesses is pancakes on his tongue, the stickiness on his fingers and on his face. He can almost *feel* the particles dissolving in his mouth and sliding slowly down his cheek, and it's *too much.*

If he's managed to stab anything other than the table in frustration, he doesn't know. Part of him doesn't even care – he doesn't hear the sound of his knife hitting anything, but feels the impact reverberating up his palm and the tension taking hold of his jaw. His hands begin to tremble as he closes his eyes and counts to *one, two, three, four, five…*

He's halfway into an attempt to calm down when something soft touches his cheek – a tissue? Then, the next moment, there's something lightly pressing at his lips. He parts them – pancakes.

Oh, no.

Part of him wants to complain – his face certainly does, by burning up. Where is his dignity? Mydei, of all people, has to mouth-feed him, and

Phainon can't quite decide whether that's the most terrible thing to have ever happened, or the best case scenario *exactly* because it's *him.* That guy will *never* bring this up in conversation. *Ever.*

At least the ridicule of the entire situation saves Phainon’s mind from that dark place for a while – maybe Mydei has the funniest grimace. Maybe he's mumbling-grumbling drivel like *‘the things I do for your snowflake ass'* while actually wearing a smile.

His peace comes because of those thoughts, but also ends with them.

“Maybe,” he begins, lips opening and closing as he conjures up the right words, *“I'll never see you again.”*

It's distressing to feel the vibrations of the sounds he's trying to make, yet not hearing a single thing. He bites into his lower lip, refusing to let it tremble, and presses his hands together on his lap to attempt to achieve a similar effect.

“It's a pity, you know. I actually like it when you smile. Looks good… for a troglodyte,” he adds for good measure. Brings a small grin to his lips, like he hasn't lost control of *every* single thing, just… *almost* everything.

Unfortunately, he doesn't receive an equally petty response or a playful punch on the shoulder.

Eventually, Mydei guides him into standing up and leads him around the house – where are they? Phainon can't seem to grasp the layout. Maybe tomorrow… whenever *tomorrow* is, he can attempt to map out his surroundings, get a grasp of how to move in this state.

When they stop, despite knowing there's nothing to hear, he still attempts to concentrate to understand what he's supposed to be doing, if anything at all. A warm touch on his back makes his breath catch his throat, but it soon becomes a yelp – Mydei removes an adhesive right off his skin. Bandages? It does feel sore. There's a few more, too, on the shoulder, chest and stomach, and a small one on his cheek. Mydei seems to unroll one from his thigh, but it's over his pants; must've been an emergency patch-up.

Mydei takes his hand after a while and stretches his arm forward; Phainon flinches in surprise for a second upon feeling hot water.

Shower time. Got it.

Phainon removes his clothes and kicks them behind him, but he really can't shake off the invasive thought that *alright, he's watching me shower, that's not awkward at all.* It's not like they never went to the bathhouse together, right? Mydei's *seen* Phainon naked before. He even commented something along the lines of “wow, your butt is bigger than your brain” one time, which earned him a slap to *his* butt with Phainon's towel.

“Well, your dick is bigger than your brain and I really hope you don't take that as a compliment,” he says in belated retaliation.

Of course, his words don't make a single sound – perhaps for the best. Standing under the showerhead provides him relief, at least, from the sensory deprivation attempting to shred his lucidity. Mydei soon presses something cold and solid to his forehead – he takes it and feels around it, eventually finding a cap at the top. He flips it open and inhales the known scent of bergamots and chamomile. His body wash?

The familiarity of that smell – and also of probability of being in *his* house, or so he hopes – puts his mind more at ease. He washes his hair first, feeling around the cold tiled wall until he finds *yes, that's my setup!* and places down the bottle he's holding so that he can free his hands.

It's like he's having this experience for the first time in his life – Phainon feels every element of the foam and bubbles forming around his fingertips and sliding down his skin, the slickness of his wet hair tickling his palm, inhales that sweet herbal scent like its source is right under his nose. It's *intense*.

Even the water itself feels different – it massages his scalp and shoulders with the pressure from the shower, but runs down his body in heavy, hot trails that contour his frame.

He releases a heavy, deep sigh and lifts up his head, hands moving to his neck to explore his own skin. It raises goosebumps down his arms, his gut flipping upside down. He concentrates on the sensation, fingertips sliding up towards his scalp, behind his ear, down his cheeks and his lips. He allows his hands to move down his chest and stomach, following his own curves, tracing his hip bones.

He's *alive.* He's really alive, and the only way he can feel it is through his skin, through the scents filling up his lungs.

It's impossible to tell whether Mydei's watching him or not, but eventually the kremnoan does turn off the shower. He drapes a towel over Phainon's head and leads him somewhere else, possibly the bedroom. He only confirms that when Mydei guides him into sitting on the bed, towel falling to his lap.

He disappears for a while. If he's getting clothes or something else, Phainon doesn't know.

A moment later a weight settles behind him on the mattress, and he's confused until the wounds on his back begin to *burn* – antiseptics, no doubt. He sucks his lower lip into his mouth and frowns until the terrible sensation ends, only to be replaced by the soothing warmth of Mydei's hand pressing fresh bandages to his skin. He repeats the same over each and every wound Phainon has, moving to the other side of the bed to bandage his chest, his shoulder, his cheek.

The injury on his thigh is the one that hurts the most. Phainon grimaces, eyebrows darting together and a silent groan escaping him. Mydei seems to notice his discomfort, because he slows down and even allows his touch to linger. It's soothing. Phainon releases a shaky breath, tired of *everything*, and leans back until his body hits the mattress.

Mydei's touch disappears and he almost regrets having laid down.

The towel’s pulled away from his lap, causing him to yell out – *“Mydeimos!”* – in surprise; that was the only thing shielding his privacy. *“You're not even taking me out for dinner first?”* he laughs, *“Rude!”*

He half expects Mydei to jab back at him with his sharp tongue, but remembers there's no possible communication between them. It's possible they'll never banter again, never exchange a good laugh after a glass of alcohol loosens them up enough to be openly friendly. He may not see Mydei and his too-good-for-a-troglodyte smile anymore, and these were already rare to begin with. There's also all the things that are *not* Mydei that he may forever miss out on, but just considering thinking about those makes him exhausted.

The duvet is soon draped over his body, which he guesses ends this bout of interaction, and what little hints of contentment he had managed to gather quickly dissipate.

“Mydei,” he murmurs weakly, pressure building inside his chest and behind his eyelids, *“I’m not okay.”*

His silent admission goes unanswered.

Chapter End Notes

I know what you're thinking and no, Mydei didn't peek. He is a gentleman. (´⊙ω⊙`) !

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Guess who hasn't completed the 3.0 quest yet? **cries in moms don't have much free time** I really hope I haven't been butchering their personalities too much! I'm making an effort I SWEAR

Out of absolutely nowhere, there's a *bump.*

Mydei opens his eyes – fuck, they're sore. It's still dark out. Silence. His eyelids slide right back down.

Badonkadonk.

He turns around on the bed, forcing his eyes to stay open and stare at the ceiling while straining his ears to listen some more. Silence. He glances at the clock on the wall – fifteen past three in the morning. His jaw pops with a yawn, eyes watering up with the tempting sleepiness washing at them. He closes them once more.

Bump— *crack. Clatter.*

Mydei sits up with his body tingling from sleep, eyes nearly crossing from lack of control. Bad cycle to wake up from, he muses. He throws his legs off the bed, getting up with yet another yawn and both hands rubbing at his

face to try and stay awake. He doesn't sense any danger, so what in the nine layers of hell could be making all this ruckus?

It's difficult to navigate the unfamiliar house in the dark, especially when his eyes *really* want to stay closed, but he manages. Scratching his tummy, he turns a corner—

—to see Phainon, completely naked – perhaps it’s best to offer him *clothes* after he's done showering next time – crouched in the middle of the living room, trying to pick up who knows what from the ground.

“Phainon,” he calls out with hope, “Do you have *any* idea what time it is? It's *fuck-you o’clock.* Go back to bed.”

Of course, no response. Well, an attempt was made – sighing, Mydei looks around for the light switch and turns it on, spewing a few incoherent curses at the sudden glare before looking at his protegee once more.

He's currently picking pieces of a broken flower vase from the floor; seems he knocked it out of the coffee table. Mydei curiously approaches, but hurries in his steps once he realizes just how *perilous* that activity is – in order to find the broken pieces, Phainon keeps sliding his hand around the floor and getting it caught on the jagged edges.

“Seriously?! Why wouldn't you just leave this to me?!” the kremnoan barks as he crouches in front of Phainon, taking his wrists to make him stop. The Deliverer glances at his direction but makes no attempt to release the shards

he's already holding. Mydei has to actually take them from him and place them on the table.

Returning his attention to Phainon's hand, Mydei grimaces at the many small cuts he acquired, specks of liquid gold and humid dirt all throughout. “You’re bleeding,” he whispers out loud, more to himself than anything. If Phainon didn't look so unhappy, the kremnoan would absolutely smack him across the head for dealing with harmful things on his own in his vulnerable state.

“You may be an idiot for doing this, but I suppose I understand where you're coming from,” he says as he's guiding Phainon into standing up, “I would want to do as many things on my own as I possibly could if I were in your place. There *is* a limit to everything, though, like *this right here.* Dumbass.”

Careful not to step on the shards or to cause Phainon to do it, he leads them back to the main bedroom and towards the bed. He leaves the Deliverer there, his back to the headboard, to get the first aid kit one more time.

He sits across from Phainon — “You know what, let's not keep your broadsword out in the open,” he grumbles while taking a pillow and placing it on the Deliverer's lap – and takes out wet tissues and disinfectant to begin tending to his wounds. It's all small cuts, thankfully, but unfortunately these tend to sting the most – Phainon tries to suppress a grimace but, as far as Mydei's concerned, he's failing terribly.

“Hurts like a bitch, eh?”

He wonders how Phainon would reply. Probably something like *“well you're a bitch”*, with a lopsided smirk that makes it look like he thinks his remark was *terribly* intelligent.

Before he ends up creating an entire fictional conversation between them in his head, Mydei forces his focus to return to Phainon's hands. Now that the adrenaline’s going down, he's starting to get sleepy again – better finish before he falls asleep on the job.

He eventually places the last bandage around Phainon's pinky finger, and it's right then that he's overtaken by his biggest, longest yawn yet. It leaves him paralyzed for a moment, eyes watering up and jaw locking open until he's done – but by then, he's awoken all over again.

Phainon's touching his chest.

It's just his fingertips, feeling around so softly it almost tickles, slowly gliding down his sternum towards his stomach. Mydei quirks an eyebrow and keeps watching, allowing whatever experiment Phainon's attempting out of curiosity, if nothing else.

That seems to be the Deliverer's reason, too – his touch is almost timid, apologetic, his hand retreating when he reaches Mydei's navel. His lips move like he's saying something, eyes glancing away and the blue within them quivering. An apology, maybe? No way to pry. Instead, Mydei takes a hold of Phainon's hand and splays it on the center of his chest, over his heart.

The Deliverer stays unmoving for a moment, a look of either surprise or disbelief on his face, even after Mydei removes his own hand to allow him to roam free. After a moment he presses his palm more firmly, likely feeling the kremnoan’s heartbeats after receiving this half-permission, half-invitation. His touch steadily rises towards Mydei's clavicle and Phainon's other hand joins – he traces the length of the bone with his fingertips, hands splaying at the shoulders and moving slowly back to the chest.

They move up once more, never breaking off contact, instead following every curve on the path to Mydei's neck, fingers tickling the nape with a soft touch and briefly catching on his hair. He follows the angle of the kremnoan's jaw, traces his ears little by little, accompanies the arc of his cheekbones and the bridge of his nose.

Phainon is a cartographer mapping out uncharted territory, Mydei muses. He's fully concentrated, as if committing everything to memory with as most accuracy as humanly possible. His hands are large and calloused and the edges of the bandages on his fingers are choppy, but his touch is still warm and careful, *gentle* even, the heat of his palms pressing into Mydei's cheeks as he cups them both.

That serious look on his face softens for a moment, as if he's found a little treasure – he gives a few squeezes as if Mydei’s cheeks are squeaky toys and chuckles, chest moving with every sound that doesn't come out, eyes slanting to follow the happy curve of his pink lips. *Pretty.* His mouth moves like he's saying something; Mydei can't translate the sound of silence, yet it makes his face feel warm and his ribcage crammed.

He draws breath from behind closed teeth, an attempt to rewire his brain back from the idiotic, amused mush it’s apparently turned into. “The *nerve* of you to treat a prince as a toy,” he grumbles without bite, if only to distract himself from how charming Phainon’s innocent curiosity and glee are. They only increase when the Deliverer realizes he can feel Mydei talking to him by the movements of his jaw. He seems to find that interesting so Mydei then adds to the fake intimidation, knowing his actual words can’t be heard but that the grinning puppy across from him knows him well enough to understand him by proxy: “I am *not* your plaything, Snowflake. Just you w— *hnnph?! Mmh!”*

Alright, so apparently Mydei can’t speak with a bunch of fingers shoved into his mouth.

Phainon retrieves his hand before the kremnoan makes him, but it’s only to place it on his stomach as it convulses with laughter. Mydei *wants* to be angry at him, but finds that it’s impossible – he’s overtaken by an indignant, lopsided smirk. “You *menace,”* he breathes out. At least his apparent *archenemy* Phainon the Terrible is unable to hear the mirth in his voice.

To the kremnoan's chagrin, though, the exploration of his face isn’t over yet – Phainon reaches for his lips. Traces every inch of them with his thumb even slower than he'd been moving before, applying pressure to part them, humidifying them with saliva. Mydei feels lightheaded. Maybe he's stopped breathing. Can't tell. Phainon, on the other hand, simply looks enchanted and absolutely satisfied with the sheer torture he's inflicting, *happy* even.

Mydei retaliates by biting Phainon's finger.

The Deliverer seems to yelp in surprise, but ultimately chuckles at the attack. He removes his hands from Mydei's face only to slide them up his scalp, fingers weaving around his hair and sliding down the strawberry blonde locks. He tries to talk again, lips moving without producing sound, and the kremnoan can only imagine what he's saying. Perhaps it's something about lion manes, just like the first time he touched Mydei's hair.

They'd been less sober then, relaxing in the baths together. Mydei had his back to the walls of the pool, arms behind him, while Phainon was the opposite – was sitting sideways, chest to the wall and arms folded above them. Mydei distinctly remembers what a challenge it was not to stare at the sharp curve of Phainon's naked waist. When the Deliverer reached out to touch his hair, though, it became impossible not to stare – either at the shiny water running down the skin of his broad shoulders, at the drunken pink dust on his cheeks, or at the way his tongue followed the path of his smiling lips and left them glossy and red. He'd then tucked a few locks of Mydei's hair behind his ear.

"Just like a little lion's mane," he'd murmured.

His gut flips upside down and Mydei promptly decides that's enough touching for the night. He takes Phainon by the wrists to take them off him, and only realizes how rough he was when the poor thing flinches. He immediately softens his grip, but judging from how the joy fades from Phainon's face, the damage has long been done. "I'm sorry," he whispers genuinely, despite knowing his apologies won't be heard, "I was careless."

In an attempt to explain away his unfortunate reaction in a way the other will understand, Mydei swallows down his pride and places Phainon's hand over his racing heart. Though the Deliverer stays still as if processing the

information and the slightest rosy tint befalls his cheeks and the tips of his ears, it's hard to know whether he's been forgiven or not, especially since Phainon looks away and doesn't even attempt to say a thing.

Mydei ultimately releases him, a tired sigh pushing out of his ribs. Hopefully his actions haven’t irreversibly hurt the trust Phainon has in him and they'll both forget about this by the time morning rolls around.

It seems to be getting steadily easier to recollect himself each time he wakes up from slumber – the confusion until Phainon remembers his current situation and adjusts to it has been diminishing, and the sense of dread keeping him bound in place, like his veins are filled with liquid lead, is slowly vanishing. That’s good, he thinks.

He still can’t get out of bed.

It took him a while to fall back asleep after what happened – feels like he terribly fucked up. He enjoys tormenting Mydei, yes, and provoking him to elicit entertaining responses, but it’s *never* been his intent to make the man uncomfortable. Makes him second-guess that interaction from the very beginning – was Mydei feeling uneasy then?

What *did* it mean that Mydei's heart was racing? Was he anxious? Happy? Embarrassed, nervous, *excited?* That gesture didn't answer any questions

more than it raised them.

Phainon presses the heels of his palms to his eyes until it begins to sting and takes a breath deep enough to strain his lungs. Once he’s sufficiently diminished the storm brewing inside his chest, he decides that the only way he can make up for what happened is becoming independent enough that Mydei won’t have to babysit him anymore.

He actually started doing that the last time he got up – wanted to move around the house and get an idea how to locate himself and the things around him, but all he did was bump into every possible piece of furniture he could and break what he’s *sure* is – *was* – his favorite flower vase. Well, he’s not too disheartened yet… in fact, he’s even *more* intent on doing things right and getting used to this *hopefully* temporary ailment.

The difference is that before, he wanted to map out the house just so he wouldn’t be entirely dependent on Mydei and to feel more like himself rather than a statue, and now… he wants, *needs* complete autonomy.

He psychs himself up – *no bumping into shit this time* – and gets off the bed only to become completely disoriented. He attempts to make a rendering of his bedroom in his head, but it's difficult gauging the distance between everything and even knowing the direction he's really facing when he's so used to relying on his sight.

Of course, the first thing he does is bumping his knee into the nightstand. At least that helps with his orientation… *kind of.*

The first order of business is finding his clothes. He attempted to do that the last time too, but ended up finding the door instead and left to walk around the rest of the house, but he's not losing his focus now – his privates have been freshened enough that they're practically brand new; he needs some underwear *pronto.*

He repeats the route he took in his last attempt, tiny step by tiny step, but instead of going through the door he continues adjacent to the wall until he hits his wardrobe. *"See, wasn't so difficult,"* he tells himself with a small smile. Now he just has to feel around every handle until he *thinks* he has the right one and finds his underwear drawer.

It takes him about half of an eternity, but he's still proud of himself when he manages to fully dress up – a shirt, underwear and pants… even if he had to sit on the floor to be able to put on the last two items. He retraces his steps towards the door and moves out, unable to rely on any walls to reach the kitchen for a most needed glass of water because of all the free space he now finds himself with.

Now that he's out of the sanctuary of his room, he doesn't allow himself to look weak and worried. Instead of tiny steps, he takes confident strides – though with his arms outstretched, hands at the ready to serve as the first point of contact – even when he has no idea where he's going.

"Kitchen, a-kitchen, I wanna find my kitchen," he singsongs, just to deescalate the stress building up inside him. His limbs feel rigid, his core shaking, every inch tread into the unknown further accelerating his heartbeats. He finally comes upon something, extended palms hitting something soft and warm—

—like flesh.

His breath catches up in his throat and it's *painful,* thorns rather than oxygen. He immediately retreats, moving away – maybe backwards; he doesn't know, he's moving *somewhere* – but his lower back meets something cold and stiff – *the kitchen counter?* – while cold sweat forms on the back of his neck.

“Mydei—”

Before he can even *formulate* his next words, the kremnoan pulls him into his chest, arms firm around his waist. His nose blows hot air next to Phainon's ear and at his hair, causing the locks to tickle his skin; the effect is intensified when he whispers *something,* perhaps a small *nothing* right into his ear. It melts him. Melts his core, melts his structure, melts his *all* when one of Mydei's hands slide up towards his scalp and presses him closer.

He hadn't noticed how harshly his heart had been thundering until it began to calm down – until he breaks free of his hesitation and slowly embraces Mydei back, arms locked around his neck and his face burying within. He draws in a shaky breath – smells *warm,* like the sun and melted sugar and spiced cider. Like *safety.*

“...I didn't fuck up at all, did I?”

Though Phainon receives no verbal response, the warm feeling buzzing in his chest replies with a soundly *no, we're okay.*

“*We're okay,*” he breathes out with a smile.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> As usual -- holy shit?? You've all been so nice to me and this story! It makes me genuinely happy. And, GOOD NEWS! I now have a beta reader!! ฅ^>ω<^ ฅ Kourt has been helping me out and she's AMAZING. Check out her
>
> tumblr
>
> !
>
> I hope you'll like this chapter!! ८(⋈^..^)♡

With his immediate worries laid to rest, Phainon finds himself chuckling into the crook of Mydei's neck, soft hair locks tickling his nose. *“I can't wait to ask you to hug me again when this is over,”* he says with humor, *“I'll tease you so much you'll want to kill me.”*

Mydei will have even more reasons to tease *him* rather than the other way around, but Phainon will make that sacrifice – he's always known that the gruffy prince had a softer and caring side, but had no idea he could be *this* sweet.

One time, he saw Mydei scolding one of his men in the middle of the city and, intending to deescalate the situation if necessary, Phainon approached. He was about to greet the two when he head Mydei spout a stern, “No. You *will* go home and rest.”

“But sir–”

“Do you *want* to anger me?”

“That’s not very difficult to do,” Phainon intervened, stopping beside them. The man Mydei was talking to, however, seemed to have already made his mind – while the prince threw Phainon a nasty, annoyed look, the downcrest soldier simply nodded and left.

“...what happened to him? He doesn't look so good.”

“That's exactly why I'm telling his *stubborn ass* to rest,” the kremnoan explained with a sigh. As if Phainon wasn't there – or perhaps, knowing the Deliverer wouldn't simply leave – he started to walk away.

“I wonder how long this lost puppy will follow me,” he eventually said. Of course Phainon gave him the only plausible response – an enthusiastic bark – and pretended not to see Mydei’s little smile as they walked through Okhema.

Their itinerary seemed so mundane. Phainon genuinely didn't connect two and two together when they bought a plethora of fruits, vegetables and juices, and continued on in an unfamiliar route. They reached a house that was *not* Mydei's, as far as Phainon knew, and knocked on the door. When a woman with beautiful chocolate hair and the greenest eyes opened the door, Phainon caught himself staring agape at the still very serious prince beside him.

“Sick people need to eat and rest properly,” Mydei told the woman as he pushed the groceries into her arms, “Don't let that idiot push himself too hard.”

She was surprised for a moment, but quickly recomposed herself with a beaming smile. “Oh, thank you! I'll let him know you sent your regards!”

After all was said and done, Phainon turned to Mydei and asked the question that had been eating at him, to the point of nearly hollowing him out inside – “So she's not your…?”

Mydei smirked in response, and Phainon's face heated up before the kremnoan could even begin to speak – “No. Were you jealous?” was the *heresy* he chose.

Phainon answered with his fist.

There were also small things that Mydei did when he thought no one was looking – one day, Phainon caught him freeing a spider out the window of his house. They both stopped moving, eyes wide at each other, Phainon's gaze switching between the arachnid on the windowsill and the angry half naked man with bed hair behind it.

“...what are you doing?” Phainon finally asked.

“No, what are *you* doing?”

“Watching you help a spider, apparently?”

“I'm not *helping* the spider; I'm just—”

“You're helping the spider.”

“And you're trespassing!” the kremnoan barked with his cheeks flaring red, fingers moving through his messy hair to, no doubt, *fail* at attempting to make it presentable. “Why in the nine hells are you in my backyard when I have a perfectly functional front door?!”

“...I heard those pancakes you like are on sale,” was Phainon's way of inviting Mydei for breakfast *and* to divert the kremnoan's attention from the fact that he's committing a crime. Before they left for their meal – and the promise of throwing hands later on – Mydei briefly excused himself and went to his small, surprisingly well kept – and *walled* – backyard.

Phainon had a hunch what the kremnoan was doing. Upon his return, the Deliverer smiled innocently – “Was your little friend alright?”

“...I will punch a new hole into your face.”

For weeks after that, Phainon would ask if Arachnysius – the name he gave the spider without Mydei's permission – was doing well and, to his surprise, the kremnoan had a different tale to tell every time… including admitting to offering it the occasional mosquito as a sacrifice, “to make an example for the others.”

There's even more tiny acts of kindness that he's witnessed, so yes, he *knew* all along that Mydei isn't half the heartless bastard he portrays himself as… he just never thought he'd ever have that soft side directed at him.

Mydei couldn't have been *forced* to do this, right? Phainon wouldn't call them *friends* exactly, but their hostility towards each other has no vitriol – he would say it's actually very sportsman-like.

However, Phainon considers being very, *very* hostile when Mydei attempts to part from him.

Since he's unable to voice out his indignation, Phainon settles with closing his grip around the kremnoan's neck tighter than a starving snake around a hefty snack. Mydei's voice vibrates from inside his chest into Phainon's own, maybe some sort of complaint or a request for him to calm down. He answers by not moving an inch.

Then he moves *a lot* of inches.

His world loses its axis so suddenly he's left short winded – Mydei hoists him up with ease, hot hands firm on the back of his thighs, their hips flush against one another. Despite his current deafness, Phainon *swears* he hears the sound of his own heartbeats inside his ears, and the rush of blood to his face.

He loses the breath he barely even had when Mydei lets him down on the kitchen counter he'd been leaning against, fingers immediately finding the Deliverer's stomach and tugging on his shirt.

Phainon chokes.

'Undress' is the command hidden within Mydei's gestures. It's impossible to stop the surge of heat flaring up in Phainon's gut; he attempts to close his legs, but Mydei's right between them. The pressure against his inner thighs makes him lightheaded.

Another tug on his shirt. Phainon gathers just enough of his liquid brain that he's able to send his arms the instruction to take off the apparently offending fabric before Mydei decides to rip it to shreds. It tickles his skin on the way out, leaving it prickly and sensitive, as if there's micro-bolts of electricity zapping through his capillaries. Of all the unholy things running through his mind, the one that sticks out the most is, infuriatingly, *I think my nipples are hard. Does he know that my nipples are hard? I think I'm dying. I'm definitely dying. May the Gods have my soul.*

Mydei takes the shirt from his hands. There's a small breeze that briefly kisses Phainon's heaving chest, as if the kremnoan is moving, and… the

collar of the fabric goes right back through his head.

He's mortified. Petrified. *Embarrassified.* Would bury a hole into the ground and jump right in if he could. He would *welcome the apocalypse* instead of fighting against it if he had *just one more* screw loose.

I must've worn it inside out, he belatedly realizes.

The sudden drop in adrenaline makes him release that one choked breath clogging his throat. *"Unbelievable,"* he grumbles, sliding his arms into the short sleeves, *"Is this revenge for the spider thing?"*

Since he's unable to hear what the absolute *pest* has to say about that, he decides that *yes,* Mydei was *positively, mind-numbingly* erotic because Phainon teased him for befriending a spider. That makes sense.

The thing that – surprisingly – disappoints him the most about the whole thing, though, is that Mydei's intentions weren't as immoral as Phainon's thoughts. Nothing was done with the *intent* of being sensual – that's just how the Deliverer's *stupid* senses perceived the whole thing. If only—

His thoughts are rudely interrupted by something round, small and cool pressing against his lips. Phainon frowns out of spite but still opens his mouth to accept Mydei's offering – a grape, firm on the outside, but tender and as sweet as honey inside.

Just like him.

It's the seventh time he reads this paragraph without absorbing a single word. He counted.

It's not that he's very invested in this book – it's some sort of generic fictional tale with heroes and monsters that he found on Phainon's shelf – but he *would* like the distraction. All he can think about is *why is this happening?*

The shallow, summarized version of the answer is, of course, *Phainon didn't want to let go of him.*

He's just not sure how that translated into moving around the house with the Deliverer clinging to his neck with the angriest puppy face he's ever seen, and then culminated in Mydei laying down on the sofa to read with Phainon resting on top of him; seems to have fallen asleep a while ago. He's even using Mydei's chest as a pillow like it's the most natural thing in the world.

Maybe it is.

Mydei feels strangely… *ordinary,* and not in a bad way. It's like he's a normal person with a normal life, and not a demigod prince with blood and death in his hands. It's a separate world within these walls – slow and peaceful, bright and warm as if the sun is constantly cradling them.

He gives up on reading entirely – leaves the book on the backrest and allows his eyelids to slide closed, fingertips lightly tapping a melody without rhythm into Phainon's ribs. He wouldn't mind sleeping like this at night. It could actually be very useful to signal to the Deliverer that it's nighttime, and that he shouldn't go around knocking random vases off furniture.

Would Phainon share his bed with him? Probably. He's been so clingy, it's almost sad – he must be relying a lot on his sense of touch to stay sane, and —

And Mydei is the only one around.

He opens his eyes. Stares at the ceiling. There's a pit forming in his stomach.

It's not difficult to imagine Phainon in this situation with someone else – who doesn't like this charismatic puppy? He seems like he doesn't dislike many people either. It's easy to picture a pair of feminine, gentle hands carding through Phainon's hair and his smile in return; easy to picture him laying on another person's chest.

He stops tapping on the Deliverer’s ribs.

Tribbie… may have been right. Maybe Mydei *did* want to do this. If you want a job well done, do it yourself, no? But they never asked for Phainon's opinion; couldn't. Would he prefer to have someone else care for him? Someone with more tact, more gentleness, more patience? Someone that simply *isn't Mydei?*

The answer is so crystal clear that it makes him sigh in frustration. He pinches the bridge of his nose and tries to will away the discomfort in his gut, but it doesn't work. His blood feels like it's running cold – *I shouldn't be here,* his brain plays on repeat. It's deafening.

It takes him a moment to notice that Phainon’s awakening – slowly sits up on Mydei's lap, one hand on the kremnoan's abdomen for support while the other rubs at his eyes, a silent yawn briefly contorting his features. He blankly looks around, eyes still lacking focus but ultimately stopping in the direction of Mydei's chest.

Phainon seems to say his name. His hands blindly roam over Mydei's torso towards his neck, then find his face just like he'd done the night before, hands pressing heat into his skin.

He's smiling. Looks absolutely angelic – snow white hair crossing the blues of his eyes and casting shadows over his cheeks, his curved lips the faintest peachy-pink. They move as he says something else, allowing a small peek at his rosy, glistening tongue.

A discomforting flush of heat burns the nape of Mydei's neck, the tips of his ears and his cheeks. He sits up intent on leaving, trembling hands on Phainon's arms – and remembers himself committing the same mistake just the night before.

Phainon waits, quietly, for his rejection. It shows in his eyes and in the way his smile fades. He seems anxious. Mydei breathes, but it isn't enough. *I'm sorry,* he'd said the night before, *I was careless.*

Fighting against his impulse to leave, Mydei instead mimics Phainon's gesture and hesitantly cups his boyish cheeks, enticing a look of surprise. His skin is so soft it tickles Mydei's calloused hands, and his face fits so well in his palms that it's difficult to want to let go.

"You're feeling more confident now, aren't you? Moving around the house," Mydei murmurs, fingers moving towards Phainon's scalp, "Dressing up on your own. Being stubborn."

The Deliverer seems to melt under his touch – closes his eyes and relaxes, a small smile returning in tandem with a chuckle, his cheeks and the tip of his nose flushing a healthy pink. Mydei's heart skips a beat; he orders it to behave.

"...maybe you don't need *me* specifically anymore. You just need to *not be alone.*"

Perhaps it's best that Phainon can't hear him – he would definitely notice the lack of conviction in Mydei's voice.

“I'll talk to Aglaea,” Mydei ultimately whispers, “We'll find someone more suitable to be your caretaker.”

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> Almost 1000 kudos, what the fuuuuuck? I feel so honored!! Like, seriously!! And everyone's comments are so kind (AND FUNNY OMG I also read the bookmarks and it never fails to amuse me); I'm blessed to have you all reading this story!!
>
> Thank you as usual, Kourt, for all your help!!
>
> Y'all have a nice read!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei keeps glancing at the clock on the wall – *"Give me a couple hours and I'll be there,"* Aglaea told him. He sighs and returns his attention to the pan he's holding, chopped vegetables turning an appetizing golden. It smells nice and he *knows* the taste will be satisfactory, yet he has no appetite.

Phainon's on the table behind him, drinking juice and feeling around the table for things to mess with. He almost tipped his glass over twice already, shoved his hand into a sugar container, smeared whipped egg whites all over his face and fell back on his chair when attempting to balance on it. He had the guts to *laugh* about it while a worried Mydei felt around for any cracks on his thick fucking skull.

Honestly, he hoped that those many shenanigans would make him angry, that he'd lose his patience or that he'd feel *anything negative* that would make parting ways easier but… to his chagrin, everything Phainon does has the opposite effect: it's all too endearing.

When the food is done, Mydei sits beside him and offers him a plate, guiding his hand to the spoon on the side. Phainon finds the edge of the plate with his free hand and seems to use some mental measurement to find where to dip the spoon – he succeeds, despite some vegetables falling down, and takes the first mouthful.

His cheeks puff out as he's eating, eyebrows rising on his forehead – he seems pleased. There's a small smile playing by his lips as he carries on eating, though he does show occasional irritation when failing to capture anything with the spoon and it reaches his mouth completely empty. Before the annoyed puppy ends up deciding to go for violence, Mydei takes the cutlery from him and feeds him himself.

Phainon happily eats everything. Once full, he swats the air until his hand lands on Mydei's shoulder and follows a trail up towards his face. He briefly cups the kremnoan's cheek, fingers rising to move through his hair while a saccharine smile curls up his lips and his blue eyes. His mouth moves in a hypnotizing fashion as he gives a clear *"thank you."*

Mydei attempts to reply. Nothing comes out. There's a knot in his chest locking everything down, scribbles of black ink that leave cold trails inside his ribcage.

"I miss hearing your voice," is the whisper that he manages to exhale.

He takes Phainon's hand and lowers it back to his face, enjoying how warm it feels against his skin, until it reaches his lips. He closes his eyes just so he doesn't have to see Phainon's reaction when he plants a kiss to that

calloused, bandaged palm. He allows the touch to linger, savoring the fake little piece of heaven he's fabricated until it's brutally shattered by a knock on the door.

Mydei gets up in a rush, nearly knocking back his chair as he goes. He refuses to look at Phainon while guiding him throughout the house towards the front door, heart beating shallowly and a dizzying pain coursing through his jaw as he locks it tight.

He takes a deep breath to calm down before opening the door to see Aglaea. *It's time.* “Thank you for coming,” he greets mechanically.

“I came as soon as I could,” she greets back, “Did something happen?”

“...come on in,” he diverts, “I'll make us some tea.”

“Thank you for the hospitality,” Aglaea says with a small smile, bringing the teacup to her lips for a sip. “Hmm. Honey and ginger,” she nods to herself, “Nice flavor.”

“It's Phainon's favorite,” Mydei blurts out before thinking twice, and immediately slaps a hand across his own face. *Stupid.*

The blonde sitting on the armchair chuckles, one hand covering her mouth. “You really do know him well.”

“Ugh. Please,” he grumbles, “It's not that difficult to know what tea someone likes.”

“Then what about me?”

Mydei bites his tongue – he has no idea. Scowling in embarrassment, he glances beside him on the couch to see a content Phainon drinking from his cup, legs crisscrossed. He gives a sigh of relaxation, leaning against the backrest.

“...any leads about this curse?” is his pitiful attempt at changing the subject.

“As of now, we’re still gathering information. I should hear from Tribios soon.”

“... I see.”

An uncomfortable silence falls. He's not sure whether Aglaea feels that way too, though; it's possible he's just anxious. Mydei looks at Phainon again; he

quickly finishes his tea – that was fast; did he even really taste it? – and leans forward to try and place his cup on the coffee table.

He fails. The cup falls to the floor and breaks loud enough to make Mydei cringe; Phainon stretches his arms over his head and leans back on the couch looking very proud of himself.

“...is everything alright?”

“Yeah. Just Phainon being Phainon,” he sighs. “I can't do this anymore, Aglaea. Find someone else to look after him.”

She's quiet, her expression the only indication that she heard him and is at all surprised. She takes a pensive sip of her tea before holding her cup over her lap. “Is it too difficult?”

“No. Not at all,” he shakes his head.

“Then why would you quit, if you don't mind me asking?”

“I *do* mind, actually.”

“Tell me anyway.”

Typical Aglaea. Mydei imagined it would get to this, though. “I'm not fit for this,” he explains, “I'm a warrior. This isn't what he needs, or even what he *wants.”*

“So you're saying you know what he wants.”

Mydei's mouth shuts closed. He looks around as if trying to find the words to answer, finally settling with an exasperated “You know I can't exactly ask him about it.”

“Then why make assumptions?”

“They're not baseless and you know that.”

“I don't. What I know is that Phainon feels safe around you in this condition, and that's exactly what he needs right now,” she insists.

“Alright. Let me phrase it differently,” he frowns, “I'm the one who doesn't want to do this anymore. Better?”

Aglaea doesn't say anything for a while. She seems to be weighing his words and doesn't seem very satisfied with them, but respects his decision anyway – “...alright. I’ll have him stay with me until Tribios can help.”

She places down her cup and stands up at once, hands crossing over her lap. Mydei feels strangely hollow, apathetic as he gets up and aids Phainon into doing the same, careful to go around the broken cup pieces.

This is it, is what goes through his mind while leading the Deliverer to Aglaea. *He'll be fine,* as she takes Phainon's hand and his smile falters. *He wouldn't choose me if he had the option,* as she begins guiding him to the door. *He'll be so relieved,* while Phainon looks around like a lost puppy. *He won't miss me,* as the Deliverer stops moving altogether, chest rising and falling quickly.

"He'll get used to it," he says out loud, smothering whatever Aglaea was about to say.

He'll get used to being touched by another person. He'll lean on them for support, map out their face with his calloused fingers and take naps on their lap. He'll hold their hand like it's an anchor keeping him at bay, show them his vulnerable side, give them that smile that makes Mydei feel dumb. Maybe they'll feel dumb too.

Maybe.

Maybe Phainon will look for Mydei later. Maybe he'll be disappointed not to find him. Maybe he'll miss eating Mydei's food. Maybe he'll think he's being rejected again, that Mydei abandoned him, that he did something wrong. That he's a *burden.* That Mydei didn't want him.

Just maybe.

Aglaea gasps – Phainon’s snatched his hand away from her and begins moving around, swatting blindly at the air. His chest quickly rises and falls, breath visibly shallow, eyes darting everywhere in distress.

His lips move to form Mydei's name.

Mydei moves so fast that he misses the transition between standing in one place and holding Phainon in his arms in the next. His grip is so tight he fears it may hurt the Deliverer, his heartbeats so vigorous they quake his frame. He can't breathe. Pushes his face into the creak of Phainon's neck and closes his eyes so tightly he sees stars.

“Aglaea,” he calls out, pausing to bite at his lower lip. He tastes blood. Takes a breath. “Please leave.”

If she replies, he doesn't hear it. Doesn't care – he'll apologize later for wasting her precious time. The only thing that matters right now is Phainon embracing him back, fingernails digging into the skin of his back hard enough to burn, a shaky sigh blowing at the nape of his neck.

“I'm sorry,” he whispers, “For being selfish like this.”

Whatever the hell happened, it's over. Phainon won't try to make sense of things out of his reach; he has enough problems to deal with and there's no way he's adding to that of his own volition. He can question Mydei later, or at least he hopes he will be able to.

The kremnoan eventually parts from the hug and leads him to the shower, helps him brush his teeth and offers him a fresh set of clothes after he's done. To Phainon's surprise, Mydei even dries his hair with the towel and combs it for him as he's sitting on the bed. *"Heh, feeling like pampering me today?"* he inquires. *"Too bad we can't talk. I miss making you annoyed on purpose."*

Phainon's body feels heavy. He lies down, the mattress plump, the sheets soft and cool against his skin, the pillow a cloud of comfort beneath his head.

"I miss a lot of things about you," he admits. *"Did you know you avoid eye contact when you're lying? And your ears blush when you're embarrassed. I think it's cute."* He chuckles low, tired. *"You'd punch my teeth in if you knew I find anything about you cute."*

There's weight on the bed beside him. Mydei's fingers card through his hair, nails grazing at his scalp – *heavenly.* Phainon closes his eyes and turns around on his side, facing the kremnoan's direction.

“Your hair looks like it's on fire when the sunset hits it just right,” he continues, *“And your eyes crinkle when you smile. Your voice drops an octave when you're sleepy – sounds nice. I like your voice.”*

A yawn interrupts his thoughts. He curls over himself, Mydei's fingers continuing their holy work on his scalp.

“And you're not nearly as discreet as you believe,” he smiles, *“I know you look at me when you think I'm not paying attention. I never told you because I don't want you to stop.”*

The mattress shifts – Mydei must be getting up. He drops the duvet over Phainon's body; the Deliverer sighs in defeat – time to sleep, it seems.

“Maybe I'll tell you someday,” he quietly whispers, *“How you make me feel alive.”*

For now, all he can do is catch some shuteye—

Mydei settles beside him again, shifting around, moving the duvet to, what, cover himself up too? The fuck's going on? Is Mydei actually *staying?* Phainon doesn't protest in any way, shape or form – doesn't even move just to make sure he won't scare the kremnoan away.

After a while, though, he can't help but seek the comfort of Mydei's warmth – slowly but steadily, his hand moves over the bed in a hesitant search. His fingertips find a source of heat and softly feel around it, discovering Mydei's own fingers. He cautiously entwines their pinkies, and it's such a silly and childish motion it makes him blush – he feels the hotness creeping up his face like a lava riptide, but doesn’t retreat. He's pretty sure Mydei's asleep.

…not.

Because he pulls away, and Phainon only has the fleeting thought of feeling like shit before it disintegrates – Mydei pulls him towards his body, locking a muscular arm around Phainon's waist and pushing one leg between the Deliverer's own. With his face buried into Mydei's massive chest, he can barely breathe, and when he does, the scent of melted sugar and spiced cider swirls sharply inside his lungs, inebriating him.

He feels his heartbeats inside his ears. Feels his skin prickle with hot electricity where their bodies converge, feels his bones rattling as he trembles and pulls himself closer, holding Mydei even tighter. Phantom bubbles rise up his ribcage, pushing up his throat and locking it while a hot surge brews behind his eyes. The pressure hurts his skull, so he releases it – takes a shaky breath and allows his walls to come crashing down.

He's lonely, scared, nothing makes any fucking sense, he's *angry,* so angry he could kill something, *so angry he could die.* He's frustrated by the lack of communication, he misses the adrenaline of a fight, he misses *being useful.* He's afraid that he'll stay this way for so long he'll forget what the sky looks like, what music sounds like, how to use his vocal chords.

He's afraid he'll be a burden. That Mydei will get tired. That he'll *leave.*

He screams into Mydei's chest. Cries in ire and sadness and resentment until his eyes hurt, and until his throat feels sore – until he's so tired that he forgets what he was even upset about.

The only thing left in his silent little world is the cadence of Mydei's heartbeats echoing into his chest, and it easily lulls him to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> CH6 may take a little while longer to come out - I'm planning a MyPhai oneshot for valentine's day, "Lion in a Bed of Roses". Yes, that's a pun. No, I'm not proud of it LMAO

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> I'm so happy you guys have been liking this so far!! Thank you all, from the bottom of my heart!! I laugh and smile like a fool every time I see a new comment hahasfauigb
>
> I'm sad that I wasn't able to finish that Valentine's oneshot I wanted, but at least I have this to offer! I hope you'll enjoy it! :D

Phainon opens his eyes but no light shines into them. This darkness that he's slowly been getting familiar with keeps him sleepy, drowsy, cocooned in an intense warmth that keeps his muscles so relaxed they may as well be liquid. In contrast, though, his groin feels tight, tense, pressure building towards an epicenter that *burns* with heat – his cock.

He's not even sure whether he's awake or still dreaming, because it feels *wet* inside his pants. His skin crawls with sparks of fire from the inside out, his heart thundering in a rhythm so relentless it leaves him short of breath.

There's an arm around his waist, a hand on his stomach, a chest pressed flush against his back. To worsen the state of his already nigh delirious mind, there's a leg pushed between his own from behind, high enough to constrict his strained balls… and something *stiff* pressing against his ass.

He breathes through his mouth, fingers curling around the sheets, his back arching so that he presses harder against that overwhelming warmth – *Mydei.*

The kremnoan is most certainly asleep, if his steady breaths and heartbeats are anything to go by. Why did he have to hold Phainon so tight? His palm feels so hot on the Deliverer's stomach he might as well be branding him, and it doesn't take long to imagine it grabbing Phainon's cock with calloused roughness, squeezing, stroking him to near completion only to hold his orgasm back with a smirk.

He misses it *so* badly – that feral curve of Mydei's lips, the intense golden of his eyes, the way his hair casts shadows over his face. He misses going to the bath with Mydei and catching glimpses of his wet, nude body; misses seeing the handsome prince unwrap the towel hanging low on his defined hip bones to reveal a thick, large cock that looks all too heavy over his thighs.

That same length briefly twitches against his ass, fully rigid. Phainon draws breath through his teeth, holding back from clenching his thighs around Mydei's. Feels like he could cum with just the man's voice on his ear.

He carefully lowers his hand towards his pants, doing his absolute best not to startle the sleeping kremnoan, and dips his fingers down the waistband. His fingertips glaze over the head of his cock, the extreme sensitivity nearly causing him to jolt with a shock of pleasure – he's drenched in precum, leaking like a needy whore; made his underwear wet.

He can't stop himself. Grabs his throbbing cock and slowly strokes down the length, aided by the slickness of his fluids, and it's like he's touching himself for the first time – he feels his veins sliding over his palm, the skin stretching over the engorged flesh, a drop of precum running down the side of his finger. Every inch he crosses brings a torrent of sensations, from the

waves of liquid fire pooling in his gut to the way his muscles contract with pleasure.

Mydei's heart keeps beating against his back, breath hot on the nape of his neck, cock throbbing against his ass every time Phainon accidentally moves an inch. He doesn't *want* to wake the kremnoan, but the *possibility* excites him. His tongue slips out of his mouth as he pants, eyebrows drawing together, sweat pointedly running down his cheek. He's trembling. Close, so close.

His toes curl inside, muscles tensing up so tightly it hurts; his fingers clench around his wet cock and it twitches *hard* against his palm. Phainon’s eyes roll back, tension building behind his eyes as tears sprout, his abs clenching, a bundle of heat exploding in his gut – he shoots his load with a cry, hand locking around his convulsing cock.

It takes him a while to realize he hasn't been breathing. He inhales sharply, tiny spasms taking control of his extremities, hand escaping from inside his pants in a jolt. He rolls around and away from Mydei to get on his elbows and knees, panting harshly into the mattress. It's like he's attempting to contain a hurricane within a cup – his entire structure trembles, heart beating inside his throat, his lungs struggling to fill up.

After a moment, he lays his forehead on the bed and takes a shaky, but less strained breath – *slow and steady,* he tells himself. He's still dizzy, but manages to sit up and wipe at his drooling mouth. There's no movement beside him, meaning Mydei *thankfully* hasn't been awoken by his dirty deed.

Though Phainon hasn't stopped trembling yet, he decides to get up and wobbly make his way to the bathroom to at least *attempt* to clean up. He doubts Mydei will even bat an eye if he does find Phainon's stained clothes – they're both adults who *know* how the male body works – but he'd rather avoid it if possible, if only to maintain the remaining shreds of his privacy.

After struggling to find the dirty laundry basket in the bathroom, Phainon busies himself with a quick shower. He's feeling better already, but…

It's impossible not to think about Mydei and his warmth, his large hands, his lopsided smile, his scent. It's impossible not to think about the beautiful curves of his body, his inviting chest, his huge—

Phainon slaps both hands across his own face. Keeps them there. *"Fucking stop,"* he tells himself, in an effort to keep it down.

But he wants that – wants *Mydei.* He's been so *good* to Phainon, so close, so warm, so attentive, so– *So perfect.* This dynamic they have, which he currently can't even put a label to, has steadily been ceasing to be enough. Would Mydei like it if Phainon kissed him on the cheeks, on the lips, all over his body? Maybe.

Maybe he would smile if Phainon told him *I like you. I like you a lot.*

Maybe I even—

“Unbeliavable,” Phainon whispers as he crouches to interrupt his own thoughts, burying his head between his knees. His cheeks are burning.

Mydei doesn't think he'll *ever* be able to finish this damned book.

He's not particularly invested in it, but it's still frustrating to sit down to read and fail to concentrate – the words just won't make sense. Phainon's fault, as usual. Mydei's getting used to them touching all the time, no problem there, but it *is* an issue when his mind is supposed to be somewhere else.

He's thankful there hasn't been any emergencies so far. He couldn't imagine leaving this puppy all alone, and even less focusing on any sort of battle when all his mind has been able to conjure is an incessant string of *Phainon this, Phainon that, look what Phainon's doing now,* and he's not even sure what or who to blame for this stupid little hyperfixation.

This time, in particular, he's losing his mind just because Phainon's playing with his hair.

He’s laying on Mydei's lap again, silvery strands of hair curling over Mydei's thighs and over Phainon's cheeks. Looking into his eyes is like staring at the sky, distant yet breathtaking; it's a show every time he blinks and his eyelashes reveal their glossy surface once more.

His veins show through the milky skin of his arm, raised so he can toy with Mydei's braid. The kremnoan can't help but follow the blueish paths as they branch around, curl over muscles and disappear beneath tendons. He's a marble statue shaped as a man, every curve, twist and turn precisely chiseled into his frame, from his expansive chest rising and falling peacefully, to his narrow waist adorned with a gold string, to the toned thighs escaping from beneath the short cotton tunic he's wearing.

Mydei's eyes follow the length of Phainon's legs, stretched on the couch. They look like they go on for miles, ending at his surprisingly delicately crafted ankles, crossed one over the other.

He has the sudden urge to shower Phainon in jewelry, cover him in layers of gold – rings for his long fingers, bracelets to follow the arch of his muscles, chokers and necklaces to adorn his pale neck, anklets, thigh chains, earrings.

“I know what would look good on you,” he murmurs, reaching for Phainon's face to gently push away the locks of hair falling over his face. He tucks the snowy strands behind Phainon's ear and follows its length all the way to the lobe. “Long earrings… with encrusted sapphires.”

It's not hard to imagine Phainon wearing something like that – to picture shiny strings of the purest gold brushing over the tips of his naked shoulders as he turns around to offer Mydei a smile. Makes his face feel warm.

A couple of knocks on the door makes him realize he hasn't let go of Phainon's ear and that the Deliverer has *definitely* noticed, if his grin and the pink shade of his cheeks is any indication. Mydei clears his throat to rewire his brain into functioning properly and aids Phainon into sitting up, patting his head to let him know he'll be back.

Quite honestly, he's only mildly surprised that there's a visitor. He supposes it's Aglaea, about to *kindly* ask him if he's finally taken his head out of his ass and is ready to apologize for wasting her time. Frankly? Yes, he's more than ready to admit he's made a mistake, just… not his *reasons why.*

When he opens the door, though, the one to greet him with a round smile is Tribbie. She lifts up two paper bags, eyes twinkling and cheeks rosy with mirth – “Aglaea sent gifts!”

“For Phainon?”

“For you two!” she corrects while allowing herself inside, “But we brought some things too. Savory things!”

Mydei considers asking her if Aglaea is angry or not, but ultimately decides against it – if she's sending gifts, things must be okay. Phainon *is* their golden boy, after all, and if Mydei's taking good care of him that must be all that matters.

He closes the door and follows Tribbie inside, watching with arms crossed as she attempts, and fails, to get Phainon's attention. She doesn't try

touching him, though, and Mydei can only guess that it's because of the way he previously reacted to her – can't blame any of them for that. “Do you think he's getting any better?” the redhead asks, a finger to her chin and her head tilted to the side.

“No. Should he be?”

“Oh, I guess Aglaea didn't have the time to tell you yet. We may have discovered what caused Snowy’s curse!” she announces with her hands to her hips.

“What caused it… not how to lift it,” Mydei notes with a sigh, opening the paper bags on the coffee table to look at their contents. Fruits, sweets, snacks…

“Well, we can't *directly* lift it. You see, we found traces of Zagreus’ power back where we found Snowy. There's old tales of that Titan granting wishes to people when their hearts are vulnerable, but always with a catch.”

“Mhm. So Zagreus played a prank on this idiot. I wonder what his actual wishes were,” the kremnoan thinks out loud, taking a bottle of artisanal pomegranate wine from the bag. Classy. There seems to be a small box inside as well – heart shaped? Huh.

“Basically, yeah! But all previous accounts stated that this is only temporary. Snowy will be okay! Isn't that great?”

“Of course,” Mydei mumbles. Chocolates? Heart shaped chocolates? And what's with the note on top? Looks like Aglaea’s handwriting.

“It's too bad you two probably won't spend as much time together when this is all—”

“What the *fuck?”* Mydei interrupts, glaring at the piece of paper before showing it to Tribbie, “Mnestia’s blessings? *Seriously?”*

“—aaand our job is done, *bye!”*

In a flash, Tribbie disappears. Mydei growls, turning the paper back around to read it again, thinking maybe he's seeing things… but, no. Aglaea really is wishing Mnestia's blessings on them and *‘may thy feelings be eternal’,* which he's only ever heard her tell newlyweds.

“We are *not* a couple!” he yells into the air like a lunatic. It would probably be more effective if his face didn't feel like the early aftermath of a solar eruption. Looking at Phainon yawning and stretching on the couch, he decides that ignorance *really* is bliss.

Pushing away the discomforting heat pooled in his cheeks, Mydei turns back towards the paper bags – with so many treats, it would be a waste not to properly enjoy them. Maybe a picnic? Phainon hasn't set foot outside in ages; getting some sunlight would probably be good for him. He's been

using mostly the shower too… a long, relaxing bath doesn't sound like a bad idea. If he adds some flowers and herbs—

Mydei smacks the note against his own face. It's heating up again.

“I'm just helping this idiot feel better,” he tells himself, “There's nothing even remotely weird about what I'm doing.”

There's something *decidedly* weird about what he's doing.

He stares at the water in disbelief – flower petals float around and exhale a soft, sweet fragrance. The bottle of wine is uncorked by the side, along with a crystal glass that he bets cost Phainon way too much money to be worth it. He readied a towel for the guy, too, and it's getting increasingly difficult to excuse his actions as anything other than pampering.

“I'm spoiling Phainon rotten,” he mutters in despair, a hand running through his hair, “What have I done with my life?”

Before he regrets even having this bath idea, he sets out to retrieve the Deliverer. He finds him in the kitchen, attempting to *oh Titans be damned, he's holding a fucking knife.* Mydei dashes towards him, finding a terribly

butchered apple on the cutting board in front of him and immediately taking his hands to check for injuries. Thankfully, there are none, but Phainon looks at him like he's stupid and it wounds *his* pride.

“I can't believe I'm *actually* worrying about you,” he hisses, taking a piece of the fruit to angrily munch on it.

He takes Phainon to the bath along with his slaughtered apple and helps him undress, aiding him in going into the small tub. The Deliverer sits down and seems to sniff the air; he smiles and blindly catches a few petals into his palms, squeezing before releasing them, hands moving all over the tub as if he's looking for something. Mydei, maybe? No way to know.

He crouches down by the tub to pour Phainon some of the wine, when the *little shit* finds him and pulls him into the water. He ends up between Phainon's legs, a silent laugh pushing out of the Deliverer’s rapidly moving chest. His cheeks are rosy with glee, wet eyelashes adorning his moony eyes. In retaliation for the aquatic assault, Mydei splashes water on him, which only causes him to laugh harder.

The sight makes him smile in a way that seems to reach his heart. Happiness, he thinks. While it feels nice, it also means he's doing something he hadn't planned on – lowering his defenses, allowing Phainon through the many walls he's so carefully crafted to protect his own core.

It's difficult not to. Phainon's smile is disarming, his eyes a blue abyss with no end, his touch a kiss from the sun. Warm, beautiful, tempting. *Irresistible.*

Water drops fall from his hair down to his cheeks, follow the curve of his jaw, drip to his clavicle and stream down his chest. Water pools between his pectorals, the pink of his nipples showing over the clear surface, and around his thick, toned thighs. It's hard not to touch them, not to follow the crystalline wet paths on Phainon's skin with his tongue, not to carve intimate trails of his own with his fingernails.

Mydei removes himself from in between Phainon's legs before he crosses an unrecoverable, invisible boundary. “You're ruining me, you know,” he whispers as he's removing his wet clothes – they've bathed together plenty of times before, so this is probably what this little prankster wants. Relaxing like this may prove useful for Mydei too, though, since he'll have to handle the entire city seeing them holding hands without causing any casualties.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> Man. MAN. What a difficult fucking chapter to write. I confess I'm not 100% satisfied with it (maybe it's the wording? The pacing? I DON'T FUCKING KNOW I EDITED THIS A BAZILLION TIMES PLEASE SEND HELP) but I guess I'll let you guys be the judge of that. :'D

Phainon finds the sensation of being surrounded by water quite intriguing – feels like a perfectly fitting glove, a molten veil intimately following his shape. The scent of flowers coats the inner walls of his lungs, their velvety petals occasionally tickling his skin, and he thinks it can't get any more relaxing than that until Mydei takes his hand and carefully pushes what Phainon recognizes as a wine glass onto his palm.

Goosebumps rise on his arms when their fingers touch. Phainon pretends to have more difficulty holding the glass than he really does just so Mydei's rough, warm fingers will continue steadying his grasp, if only for a little while longer.

Though that moment soon comes to an end, their physical contact doesn't – Mydei settles on the tub right beside him, their shoulders touching, and Phainon can only guess it's to make his presence known and felt. He's always so reassuring, it's a lovely side of him that very few people, if any at all, know about.

“I wonder,” the Deliverer murmurs, head lolling to the side to rest against Mydei's, *“What kind of face you make when you're holding me.”*

His lips press to the rim of the glass. *Wine*, his nose tells him. Sweet and sour fruit blends with the bitterness of alcohol and washes over his tongue, thick and pungent, warming up his face as he drinks everything, little by little. He then releases a satisfied breath, cheek nuzzling against Mydei's shoulder. His blood buzzes already, heightening his lack of spatial awareness.

“Do you like it when I beg for your attention like an idiot puppy?” he whispers, slurring over his words. The glass slips from his hand and he supposes Mydei catches it, because there's no change to the water below.

Not that he cares – he has more pressing issues at hand. *Mydei.* How could anything be more important than that? More important than huddling closer to him, one hand sliding over those perfectly sculpted abs, fingertips gliding up his sternum, palm pressing over his heart to absorb the impact of every beat. Feels like Phainon could catch it with his bare hand if he so wished.

His head lolls further to the side, and he presses a lingering kiss to Mydei's wet shoulder. *“You’re so warm,”* he mouths into the kremnoan's skin, *“Wanna stay like this forever.”*

Phainon feels like he's sinking into Mydei's body – an arm laces around his waist, pulling him closer, and he complies with all the strength of a loaf of bread. His lips move from shoulder to clavicle, then to the crook of Mydei's neck, his jaw, inch by inch, kiss by kiss, his balance hanging by a thread, his final objective steadily getting closer—

—until he slips and nearly topples over Mydei, smashing their foreheads together. He winces in pain and shame, hand blindly reaching for his injured skull; no doubt he looks red and stupid. Mydei takes his wrist, though, and pulls it away, cradling Phainon's face to keep him in place.

He kisses Phainon's forehead.

His soft lips linger for a moment, branding Phainon's skin, and it leaves behind a cold nothingness when the affectionate display comes to an end. Little drunken bubbles of *I absolutely love this man* tickle their way up Phainon's chest, attacking his heart and lodging in his throat. Despite the water around him he's positively on fire, complete with flames and embers. He slaps his hands over his face to hopefully hide a blush that's no doubt lighting up the entire Amphoreus – who the hell needs a sun when Phainon can blush this hard? – and *whines.*

At least he can't see Mydei's reaction to his pathetic little meltdown.

After their bath, that buzz of alcohol has all but left his system. Phainon wears the short tunic Mydei places in his hands and is guided into sitting on the bed, where his hair is combed for him. *“You really are pampering me, aren't you?”* he teases with a happy smile, *“Better be careful. I might get used to it.”*

Truthfully, he already is. Mydei absolutely *broke* the man Phainon used to be.

The brushing on his scalp ceases. His ankle is, surprisingly, Mydei's next target – he takes it gently despite the roughness of his palm and his natural strength, that warm touch sliding down to Phainon's foot. The Deliverer can't help but hold his breath, cheeks feeling hot; Mydei slips his foot into a sandal and repeats the same to the other.

"Seriously," Phainon grumbles, *"You're just helping me wear my damn shoes and I'm already like this. You'll be the death of me, Mydei."*

If they could communicate, Mydei would probably say that nope, he's just stupid. Since they can't, he resigns himself to his fate and allows the kremnoan to guide him around, hand in hand, making a few stops for purposes unknown. Eventually, Phainon is the one who ceases to move and lifts his arm, twisting it around experimentally, then leaves his palm turned up – feels warm. The heat seeps into his skin and bathes him from head to toe, focused on his face, his shoulders and his upturned palm.

Sunlight?

He can't see any of it, even when he looks around searching directly for the sun. Mydei lightly squeezes his hand as if reassuring him or asking about his wellbeing, possibly both; Phainon glances at his general direction and smiles – *"Did I worry you? Just surprised we're outside, is all."*

They begin moving again. Phainon is nowhere near as confident as he was inside his own home, though, where he had a familiar, small layout to work with – the outside world is expansive, their destination unknown, the occasional change in temperature from sunlight and shade disorienting.

He attempts to keep his breathing calm and steady, but finds it impossible. His grip on Mydei's hand unconsciously tightens, his ribcage constricts around his lungs, tremors start on his fingertips.

The pieces of him that seem to be scattering around the unknown are all collected by Mydei and pressed back into his frame – the kremnoan releases his hand only to hold him by the waist, pushing heat and comfort into him. Phainon closes his eyes for a moment to recollect himself, focusing on the feeling of the fingers holding him firmly, the heat radiating off Mydei, the manly but sweet scent of his perfume.

The Deliverer finally slips a hand around his partner’s waist, mimicking him, and they start walking once more. It takes a while, but it finally dawns on Phainon that they're walking around Okhema and everyone's witnessing them holding each other like lovers.

First it makes him smile, then it makes him chuckle. He presses the back of his hand to his mouth before he bursts out laughing because he can only imagine the kind of face Mydei's making – is he barking at people to back off from them? Is he explaining the situation? Allowing people to think they're *together?*

The thought makes Phainon giddy. He's not sure how he's going to handle the situation later – if ever – but right now, he's more than enjoying the idea of Okhemans thinking he's *taken* Mydei.

After a while they stop walking, but there's sudden movement beneath his feet and Phainon's gut flips upside down, his knees getting weak. He leans against Mydei, holding on to him for support until what he guesses is an elevator ride is over. Mydei continues to guide him by the waist until the very floor seems to change, feeling more muted under his sandals.

It's only when the kremnoan releases his waist and tugs on his sandals to take them off that Phainon better understands the situation – there's grass beneath him, the blades folding under his feet and brushing against his ankles. The Garden of Life? Probably. Mydei lightly pulls on his arm, urging him to sit down, and he gladly does.

Phainon allows his back to fall to the ground and lays stretched on the grass, basking in the warm sunlight while the grass tickles his naked limbs. Closing his eyes, those warm rays kiss his eyelids and cheeks, and the light breeze makes his hair dance over his face. Something cool pokes at his lips and he instinctively parts them, welcoming in what he quickly recognizes as a strawberry. Its sweet, thick juices swim in his tongue, giving a wonderful flavor to an already marvelous moment.

Sometimes – like this little snippet of time, and when he's in Mydei's arms – he thinks this whole thing isn't so bad after all. He used to think – and once *told* Mydei – that he has nothing, that he has no one, but he's slowly been adding precious things to his broken heart, stapling it back together piece by piece. It will never be the same, but it *is* becoming whole again nonetheless.

“This is your fault, you know,” he breathes out, sitting up to search for Mydei. His fingers meet the kremnoan's shoulder and snake their way down his arm, contouring the angles of his muscles until it reaches his hand, which Phainon covers with his own. *“You're so good to me. You listen even when I can't speak,”* he whispers, inching closer to Mydei, free hand reaching for his face, *“You guide me when I can't see; you hold me when I'm afraid.”*

He toys with Mydei's braid, the soft hair silky against his fingertips. Through the kremnoan's heat, Phainon finds his way closer and presses their foreheads together. *“You even take me on picnic dates,”* he adds with a teasing smile, *“You do know how romantic this is, right? Don't you feel at all guilty for stealing my heart, Mydeimos?”*

His hand slowly drops to his lap, lips starting to quiver. He bites into his lower lip to keep it still, pressure building behind his closed eyelids.

“If I get better,” he whispers brokenly, hesitantly, *“Will you leave me?”*

He imagines going back to his empty house. Imagines his voice bouncing off the walls as he speaks to himself, cooks for himself, reads in a silence that's much more profound than the one he currently finds himself in – it's not the absence of sound, but the absence of *love.*

Phainon already went through that once. Losing everything, including himself. Just going through the motions, surviving rather than living, seeking a purpose he knows will never fill the hole left behind by what he

had in Aedes Elysium. He doesn't want a Mydei-shaped wound in his soul. He won't be a broken man anymore if that happens; he will be a man *no more.*

“How can I make you stay with me, Mydei?” he murmurs, eyelashes feeling wet and nose warming up as it touches Mydei's. *“Would you even take me seriously if I told you I love you?”*

Before any of those stubborn little tears begin to fall, Mydei gently wipes them away. The warmth of his thumbs lingers on Phainon's cheeks, their coarseness comforting. Phainon smiles despite the painful knot in his throat.

“Sorry that I ruined the moment,” he chuckles humorlessly, *“Can we please go home?”*

Mydei isn't quite sure what happened. In one moment Phainon looked like the happiest puppy, and in the next he was teary eyed and tugging on his arm as if asking to leave. Maybe the experience was too much? Either way, Mydei quickly took him home after that, carrying him on his back just in case Phainon was too tired; the Deliverer didn't lift his head off Mydei's shoulder the whole way.

He makes his way into the main bedroom and carefully lays Phainon down, his head lolling to the side on the pillow, eyes closed. That explains why he

was so quiet. Mydei decides to leave him to rest and stands up, but Phainon notices the moment he gets off the bed and quickly jolts up, swatting the air to find him and cling to his arm, breathing rapidly. His mouth moves to form Mydei's name, and he doesn't need anything else to grasp the hidden request – *stay.*

Mydei gently pushes him back down and holds his hand over the pillow, dipping his fingers between Phainon's. He looks so unimaginably pretty – shoulder showing where his tunic slipped off, his nose and cheeks rosy, slanted eyes the deepest shade of blue. He says something unintelligible, bringing attention to his peachy-pink lips. His tongue runs over them, leaving them glossy and inviting, and Mydei draws in a shaky breath.

He moves closer, kneeling on the bed to tower over Phainon, his shadow engulfing the Deliverer's alabaster skin. Their chests press together, sharing warmth, as he lowers his face to Phainon's and watches his hair fold and curl over those rosy cheeks. They're so close their breaths mingle, the tips of their noses touch, their hearts thrum into each other's ribcages.

Phainon doesn't move away from him. Instead, squeezes his hand as if urging him to move, his lips parting, half lidded blue eyes drawing him in. Mydei finds it impossible to resist, and frankly doesn't even want to – he closes the remaining distance between them, eyelids sliding down, humid mouths pressing together.

Mydei draws in breath sharply, his walls irreversibly crumbling down. He pushes harder against Phainon's lips, sucking the lower one into his mouth and grazing with his teeth while trembling fingers run through his hair. Phainon retributes by flicking his tongue against Mydei's and pushing his body off the bed, seeking further intimacy. There's no rhyme or reason to

how they move, to how they grind their hips, to how they devour each other's mouths. It's raw passion, a competition with no loser.

Mydei groans when their tongues slide heavy against one another, curling over; his eager partner grabs him by the hair and deepens the kiss, licking the roof of Mydei's mouth and purposely sucking his breath away. He's desperate, is the impression Mydei has, and it's reciprocated with just as much intensity – he sucks on Phainon's tongue and pushes one knee between his legs, parting from the kiss to watch the object of his affections losing his mind.

Phainon's body arches off the bed, thighs clamping around Mydei’s. The Deliverer pushes his hips up, canines showing in a needy snarl, an obvious erection beneath his tunic as he claws into the kremnoan's shoulders. Mydei grabs his thighs from under the fabric, his breathing heavy and thoughts clouded, nails sinking into toned flesh. Licking his lips, he relishes on the way Phainon writhes under his grasp; his big chest heaves, muscular legs quivering, abused lips parting so that Mydei's name silently rolls off that delicious pink tongue.

“Let’s make you say that out loud,” he whispers, leaning down to lick into Phainon's welcoming mouth.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> A SPEEDY UPDATE! It's thanks to you all for all the wonderful feedback and support... and my babygirl for not allowing me to sleep last night and forcing me to have "free time" LMAO

He would think he's dreaming if it wasn't for the weight of Mydei's hands and the delicious pang of nails digging into his thighs. Phainon's senses are ablaze, every nerve from the roots of his hair to the tips of his toes collapsing under his partner's passionate might. Mydei conquers his mouth with his hot wet tongue, leads the rhythm of their bodies with the grinding of his hips, melts Phainon with his heat and with the way his leg presses against the Deliverer's groin.

He's so hard it feels like he could burst any moment – it's steadily getting damper inside his underwear, sharp electricity zapping from his gut right up his cock. He bucks his hips up, rutting shamelessly against Mydei's leg while grabbing a fistful of hair to pull the kremnoan's head back. Phainon bites *hard* into the tender flesh, intent on leaving a brand new red mark; Mydei's throat vibrates beneath his teeth, a moan that he's unable to hear but feels resonating in his bones.

He licks the abused skin when he's done, collecting the tasty essence of Mydei's sweat and perfume. It's inebriating. He presses open mouthed kisses to the column of Mydei's neck, grazes with teeth and teases with tongue, all while clawing down the kremnoan's back in uncontrollable excitation. Phainon's a bomb exploding; all the admiration, rivalry, desires and even the *irritation* he's ever felt towards Mydei course through his veins all at once and *consumes* him.

He allows it. *Summons* that turmoil into his core, toys with the limits of his self control, because only then can his emotions truly be transmitted – *fuck me senseless, destroy me, abuse me, make me scream.* Along with that animosity, though, there's trembling fingers, little kisses, tears streaking down his cheeks, *love me, don't leave me, make love to me.*

Mydei licks his tears away. Presses kisses to his temples while undoing his tunic, his large hands everywhere, kneading his thighs, feeling his abs, fondling his chest. Phainon melts under his touch, his cock springing up as it's freed, teeth sinking into his lower lip at the thought that his nude body is fully at Mydei's mercy. The kremnoan takes full advantage of that – kisses down Phainon's throat, his pectorals, his nipples – briefly catches each one between his teeth and lips – and his stomach, hands firm on his hips to stop them from thrusting up.

The moment he feels Mydei's tongue on his cock is when he completely loses it. His eyes roll back, erection throbbing between his partner's wet lips, back sharply arching off the ground and toes curling on the sheets. His teeth grit as he tries to hold back, orgasm pushing at his gut, sweat rolling down his skin, his fingers grabbing at Mydei's hair to push his head down. His body quakes on the mattress, cock engulfed to the hilt by the kremnoan's hot, tight throat; Phainon thrusts up into that damp heat again and again, his rhythm a fast paced mess, until Mydei's name goes from a repeating mantra to one drawn one, drunken scream.

His entire body jolts with the sudden, sharp explosion in his gut – his grip on Mydei's hair tightens, quivering thighs clamping around his head as he violently shoots his load. Mydei chokes on his cock, the sensation of his throat convulsing around him deliciously obscene. Phainon’s still on that lustful high when Mydei pulls out and leaves a cold wetness behind; before

the Deliverer can even think of complaining, there's a slick pressure at his taint, moving down, further, Phainon spreads his legs like a whore for the kremnoan prince, *lower, more,* and the humid heat finally reaches his rim.

Mydei absolutely devours him. Eats him out with both tongue and lips, around the eager ring of muscle and inside his tight, needy ass. He teases with the tip of his tongue and penetrates with its whole length, curls it around like he's licking honey off the back of a cup, like he's *starving,* sends vibrations right into Phainon with groans and moans, his hair tickling the Deliverer's thighs and groin.

Phainon's cock leaks over his stomach, fully hard again – if it ever even went down – by the time Mydei gives his rim one last long, drawn out lick. His heavy length brands the skin of Phainon's stomach with its heat as the kremnoan towers over him, and ignites hot sparks inside his veins. *Big.* Phainon's nearly begging. Mydei teases him, moves his hips to make his cock slide against the Deliverer's, fervently fondles his pectorals and pinches his nipples, pulling on them, and smashes their mouths together. Phainon completely loses his mind – he tastes his own cum on Mydei's tongue, and it's *divine.*

He shoots his hand down to grab Mydei's erection, the skin stretching thin over the thick length and hefty veins, and spreads his legs as he gives the hefty girth a few good pumps, absorbs the heat radiating from the silky flesh, collects precum with his thumb. He *needs* it inside; needs to cum with Mydei buried deep inside him, fucking him raw. *"Put it in,"* he pleads, guiding his partner's cock to his awaiting hole, *"Put it in, Mydei…!"*

Phainon himself pushes down on the length, delicious warmth spreading over his rim, but Mydei stops him – pulls away. The Deliverer is about to

complain when that pressure returns, this time slick and lubricated, the soft scent of peaches reaching his nose. Soft lips move against his own, humid and gentle, a hand caressing his cheek.

Then it goes in.

Mydei slowly spreads him open, cock searing hot, his girth pushing at every inch of Phainon's walls so it accommodates its size. The Deliverer laces his arms around Mydei's neck, cheeks flaming up, heartbeats drumming inside his ears, erection throbbing and dribbling precum over his stomach. His ass stretches open for Mydei as he continues, hungry, hurts *so good* – it's a dull, warm pain that only heightens all the pleasure he feels. Mydei fills him up to the limit, puzzle pieces clicking perfectly together, his body and heart and soul all *complete*, a loving kiss to his lips. *Bliss.*

That hotness retreats only to return more aggressively, easy and slick, Phainon's body a willing offering to a hungry lion. He feels Mydei in his stomach. In his *core.* The kremnoan pulls aways again and thrusts in more harshly, again, repeats, *more, more,* he moves into Phainon hard enough to make him see stars and to use Mydei's name as prayer. His insides itch with pleasure, his body burning, his entire being consumed by euphoria, *you're so big, fuck me harder, faster, I love you.*

Mydei slams against his prostate, and Phainon *screams.* His tongue rolls out of his mouth, hands blindly grabbing at the pillow beneath his head, eyes rolling back as tears sprout and run down his face to lose themselves in his hair. Mydei doesn't stop. He takes Phainon's thighs and spreads them farther open, thrusting mightily inside, faster than before, faster, *faster, harder.*

Phainon's delirious. He loses himself, his entire structure shaken by pleasure, walls collapsing around Mydei's cock. His screams and cries of bliss are incoherent, his thoughts inexistent; euphoria overtakes him and he laughs as his muscles contract, heat coils in his gut and his climax ignites all his nerves.

“Mm– C-Cumm– innng…!”

He shoots all over himself, hot streaks pooling in his abs and sliding down his chest, and though his fluids stop, his cock continues to throb and his orgasm *stretches*, his body ablaze for as long as Mydei slams inside him, his cries of *Mydei, Mydei, Mydei, fuck me harder, I'm cumming so much*, all silent but potent, tumbling right out of his chest. The kremnoan doesn't stop, his fast pace losing its tempo, hips brutally slapping against Phainon's ass.

The kremnoan thrusts all the way in and holds, tight, his girth twitching *hard* against Phainon's walls. He thrusts a few more times, a sloppy mess, before finally pulling away, and the Deliverer crashes from the high heavens right to the ground.

His heart beats so fast it hurts. He struggles to breathe, he won't stop shaking, and the post orgasm spasms attacking his body make him whine. Tears keep pushing out of his eyes, his lips tremble and his chest jumps with sobs and hiccups, his skin aflame as if Mydei's touch left imprints, abused ass tingling. *“T-Too much,”* he weakly whispers, *“Can't… breathe…!”*

Mydei doesn't miss his state of disarray – runs his fingers through Phainon's hair, takes his hand and presses little kisses to his fingertips. It's ticklish, pure, tender; with every loving touch, that sudden surge of adrenaline further dissipates, giving space to a relaxation so intense it melts his muscles and gives way to exhaustion. He takes note of the coolness of Mydei's hair as it brushes over his cheeks, the softness of his lips, the cadence of his heartbeats as their chests meet. His consciousness further slips away with every kiss, every leisurely lick at his mouth.

"Mydei," he mumbles with a sleepy smile, *"You win this round."*

Mydei is left with the lingering taste of Phainon's mouth and the image of his wrecked, ruined, *perfect* body – lips and nipples red and swollen, sweat making his alabaster skin glisten, tears of pleasure clinging to his eyelashes like tiny diamonds. There's red marks on his chest, finger imprints on his thighs, his spent cock leaks over his chiseled stomach and cum fills his rosy, gaping hole, dribbling on the mattress. Mydei shivers at the sight, his face warm and ears tingling with his loud heartbeats.

He really just fucked Phainon.

There's no going back from this. Their relationship will irreversibly change, for better or worse.

Mydei hesitantly gets off the bed and covers the unconscious Phainon with the duvet – in his cursed situation, resting is more important than cleaning up. The kremnoan does take a quick shower himself, though, washing away the remnants of their mixed sweat and semen. He passes by the mirror on the way out and admires the marks left on his naked form – a perfect set of teeth on his neck, multiple hickeys, blazing scratch marks on his shoulders and chest. They're all a neat addition to the red markings he already has, he thinks.

“You little devil,” he mumbles with a grin, rubbing at his neck, “And I was so careful not to ruin *your* skin.”

He wears a fresh set of clothes and approaches the sleeping Phainon – he's now on his side, cheeks still pink but overall a less pronounced hue than before, a stupid little smile on his parted lips as he drools onto the pillow. Mydei’s heart skips a beat, clouds of cotton candy forming inside his ribs to rain liquid sugar. He promptly turns away from the sight and walks out of Phainon's house entirely, set on clearing his thoughts – and calming his racing heart – with a walk around town.

His face struggles to cool down. The fuzzy feeling in his chest doesn't stop, and he catches himself occasionally smiling at absolutely nothing; he covers it with his hand every time. Feels like he's losing control, like he's crossed the point of no return with his feelings and now has his heart laid bare for Phainon to take.

It's simultaneously the best and the worst feeling in the world.

He takes a look at the Amphoreus landscape, the faraway mountains, the clouds above, the buildings and trees in the distance, yet all he sees is Phainon – his cute, *stupid* puppy face drooling on the pillow; his smile and the way it makes his eyes puff out underneath; how his nose wrinkles when that smile turns into a mischievous little grin; the delectable shade of red dusting over his body when he's sweating; his tasty cock and how it fit snugly in his throat; his tight, pink little asshole—

Mydei clears his throat to send the thoughts away, sitting down on a bench to hopefully hide what's happening inside his underwear. As further distraction, he pulls out his teleslate – strangely enough, there's a message from Castorice from roughly half an hour ago. That's rare enough to be concerning – she only messages him to send pictures of flowers and animals full of glitter on early mornings at the beginning of the week, things like *'have a blessed week!'* in handwritten fonts at the bottom. He can't imagine why she'd want anything to do with him at such a random time.

Opening the message reveals, unsurprisingly, the picture of a bouquet of red roses with copious amounts of shiny glitter… and the word *'congratulations'* at the bottom. Mydei quirks an eyebrow. Instead of his typical *'thanks'* or *'you too'*, he sees that she's online and sends instead a question mark.

You: ?

You: What are you congratulating me for?

Miss Castorice is typing…

Mydei sighs and looks around, unable to sit still, his leg bouncing. This isn't proving to be a very reliable way not to think of Phainon. He can still remember the feeling of those toned thighs under his fingertips, the temperature of his body, the taste of his mouth—

Buzz!

Miss Castorice: Your engagement to Phainon.

Miss Castorice: You two have always worked so well together. I'm happy.

Miss Castorice: May Thanatos keep you together even in the afterlife.

Miss Castorice: Oh. I didn't mean to…

Miss Castorice: You can't die. My apologies.

Miss Castorice: Live, laugh, love.

…and then she sends another glittery image.

Mydei keeps staring at his teleslate, message after message, unable to decide whether the most absurd part of the whole thing is her wishing Thanatos' blessings on a supposed couple, the glitter assaulting his eyes, or the fact that she thinks he and Phainon are engaged.

You: What are you talking about?

You: Why would you think I have anything romantic with Phainon?

Miss Castorice: Oh

Miss Castorice: Was there some sort of mistake? This is all over the news.

Miss Castorice: Here

Mydei clicks the link so fast it makes his head spin. The news site opens up to show the glaring headline, *"Apocalyptic Romance! Chrysos Heirs Move Amphoreus' Hearts With Their Love!"* accompanied by the subtitle, *"Will Castrum Kremnos be Rebuilt by Two Kings?!"*

"...excuse me, what the—!"

The article was written just about an hour ago… and has thousands of views already. Mydei is so flabbergasted by the headline itself that he's not sure whether he even wants to read the rest, until he scrolls down and sees a picture. Of him and Phainon. It was taken when they were walking around town earlier, Mydei with an arm around Phainon's waist. He releases a shaky *"Oh no,"* and skims through the article, until he comes across the biggest *whatthefuckery* yet – another picture, this time of their picnic.

A smiling Phainon's hand covers Mydei's own, their foreheads pressed together, faces mere inches apart. What surprises Mydei the most, though, and makes his ears and cheeks warm up is the look that *he* has on his face –

he looks absolutely enamored. The tenderness in his gaze is visible even in his profile, like there's *love* seeping from his pores. *This* is how he looks at Phainon, wearing his heart on his sleeve, feelings out in the open for anyone to see?

His face heats up bad enough that he places a hand over it to try and placate the invading warmth. There's no denying what he feels for Phainon, no hiding the love that so silently crept up his chest and managed to escape. *I love him,* he thinks, *I love him so much,* and it makes him tremble. He lowers his head between his legs, fingers grabbing at his own hair as his heart attempts to leap out of his throat, run away, *I can't do this.*

Mydei cannot die. He's not afraid of battles, swords and spears, calamity; death itself cowers in his presence. However… right now, Phainon has the only means to crush his heart, to completely and utterly *destroy* him, in a way that death never could. Like Mydei's own flesh and blood once did to him by offering him – a mere child – as a sacrifice, Phainon can, and just might, create scars that will never heal. Love is… dangerous. *Phainon* is dangerous.

Mydei takes a breath. Glances at his teleslate again. Takes a look at Phainon's smile – at his *happiness.* Remembers the warmth of his body and his serene breathing as they slept in the same bed, huddled in each other's arms, remember their battles, their trust in each other, their *passion,* and decides that being vulnerable for Phainon – that facing that danger – is a risk he's willing to take.

He arrives home probably less than an hour after leaving. He expects to find Phainon passed out on the bed still, his pillow drenched in drool – *ugh* – but instead, sees the nude Deliverer huddled over himself on the couch, legs pulled close to his chest, knuckles white as he grips his own arms nails first. His knees are red and scraped, his thigh bruised like he bumped into something. Mydei's heart sinks.

“Phainon,” he calls out in a worried murmur, approaching the Deliverer in a hurry; he places his hand on Phainon's shoulder and he jumps in surprise in response, lifting up his head to look at his general direction with bloodshot eyes and reddish cheeks.

Phainon's lips quiver. He closes his eyes, eyebrows knitting together, his frame shaking with a dry sob. “Mydei…” he says in the tiniest whisper, “I thought you left me. Don't scare me like that, you absolute fucking dickhead.”

The kremnoan drops to his knees, trembling, his structure in shambles. He holds Phainon's hand and brings it to his lips, shaky breaths spilling onto the Deliverer's palm. He presses a kiss to it, eyelids sliding closed as they wet up, his ribcage containing a thunderstorm. *I missed your voice. I missed it so much.*

“Don’t worry,” he murmurs weakly, but meaning every word, “I'm not going anywhere.”

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> How did we reach 2k kudos?? THIS IS INSANE! Thank you thank you!!
>
> I hope you've all been enjoying 3.1 and that this chapter will be fun too! (≧▽≦)

The Deliverer is one of the most shameless, confident people Mydei knows – if he has a skill or has done something positive, he doesn't shy away from letting other people know. It's less arrogance and more wanting praise, Mydei's sure, like when they were undressing before a bath and Phainon *insisted* his biceps must be at least as big as Mydei's and to squeeze them. He went on a whole monologue about trying a new diet with more proteins and undergoing a new training regime that had him feeling *so* much stronger… so of course that meant he had to pose in various angles to show off his body.

"The brain is also a muscle," Mydei had jabbed at him, "Feel free to try exercising it sometime."

"How about *you* exercise yours by coming up with a compliment?" Phainon smirked, head tilting to the side as he crossed his arms over his naked chest, making it pop up.

Mydei sighed, mimicking Phainon's stance. His eyes roamed the Deliverer's form, the only piece of clothing covering him being his underwear, which hung *low* on his hips. Lots of curves, visibly toned

muscles, wide arms and puffy chest, his waist narrow. “Fine. I *do* notice some improvement to your build.”

“I knew it,” Phainon exhaled with a happy grin, “I guess I'll allow you to stare some more, you sly fox.”

“I wasn't *staring—*”

“You totally were.”

“You *asked* me to!”

Phainon has always been like that. He *likes* praise like the puppy he is, so why has he *never* sung in front of Mydei before? Why is he only doing it *now,* when he thinks he can't be heard?

The kremnoan watches in awe as Phainon cleans up in the shower, his melodic voice bouncing off the walls as if it has life of its own. He may be biased by his romantic interest, but it definitely feels like he's being tempted by a beautiful siren – an unknown song echoes inside his skull, timber and tone enchanting, scales made of water droplets peppered on Phainon’s shoulders and back.

When the last notes are sung and silence returns with a small sigh, Phainon's head down, Mydei thinks he may have seen something he

shouldn't. Perhaps it's a song of Phainon's people, a memento from his childhood or simply some thing or another that he'd rather keep to himself – either way, it makes the kremnoan feel guilty. He first places a hand on Phainon's shoulder, then a small kiss to its wet skin – an apology.

Phainon turns towards him, a smile quickly forming on his glossy lips. Mydei pushes away the wet locks of hair clinging to the Deliverer's skin, slicking them back, and admires for a moment as his partner blinks crystalline drops off his lashes. They land on his pale cheeks and curl down their length, disappearing under his chin. Mydei swallows down, mesmerized by the sight, and leans in to gently capture Phainon's mouth with his own, fingers weaving around damp strands of hair.

The Deliverer places his hands over Mydei's, returning the loving gesture with just as much care, lips soft and humid. It tickles when they part; Phainon draws a small smile and pecks Mydei's lips, then again, once more, and finishes with a bite that makes the kremnoan groan, heat coiling in his gut. Chuckling, Phainon presses their foreheads together and caresses Mydei's jaw, thumb pressing into the stinging bite.

“I'll mark you all over. Every inch of you,” the Deliverer whispers against his mouth, “Want you to think about me every time you look at the mirror.”

Mydei draws in a shaky breath – his composure, lost. He takes Phainon by the back of the thighs and hoists him up, their hips flush together and mouths clashing as he pushes the Deliverer against the wall. He devours the inside of Phainon's tasty little mouth with his tongue, hips rolling to stimulate their hardening lengths, skin burning under his damp clothes. He breaks the kiss to have a taste of his partner's neck, pinning him to the wall

with his weight so that his hands are free to roam over Phainon's muscular body.

“Mmh– Ah, the kremnoan prince is such a brute,” Phainon chuckles, “I wonder where I can file a complaint.”

“Complaint, huh,” Mydei breathes onto his skin, fingers reaching down to loosen his damp pants, erection springing out. He rubs it against Phainon's still tender rim; his head snaps back against the wall, cock twitching between their stomachs and eyes widening in surprise. When Mydei applies *just a bit* of pressure, massaging, threatening to push inside, Phainon whimpers and impatiently tries to lower his hips, eager moans and sighs spilling from his abused lips. “Hmph. Your body's more honest than your words.”

Careful not to allow Phainon to slip, Mydei reaches for the shelf embedded on the wall, skimming over the various beauty products and turning around those with the labels away from him. He spots a golden jasmine body oil with a thick consistency and decides that's what they're working with. He unscrews the cap with one hand with some difficulty, because Phainon keeps sucking and biting at his neck, hips pushing at Mydei's like he's trying to impale himself on the kremnoan's cock.

When he's finally lubricated and his cock head slips into Phainon, he struggles not to move further – his eyes slip closed, eyebrows knitting, muscles tensing up. His partner claws at his back, evidently desperate to get more of the length inside him, but Mydei stands his ground – Phainon may be loosened up from before, but there's no reason to risk it. Instead, he goes slow, inch by inch, swallowed by his partner's tight, wet heat until he's fully sheathed.

“How long have you wanted me to fuck you up a wall, *Deliverer?”* he asks with a smirk, cock slotting perfectly inside his partner, hips flush against his tight ass, “You're clamping around me.”

Phainon strings together moans and whimpers, his chest hammering against Mydei's. With his hair slicked back, only a few loose strands dripping water over his cheeks, all the details of his handsome face come to light – the healthy red hue of his cheeks, the cloudiness of his blue eyes, the pickiness of his tongue drawing over glossy lips. “You're so beautiful,” Mydei whispers against his mouth, cock slipping down before slowly moving back in, repeating, again, slow enough that he feels the way Phainon spreads and tightens around him.

“Mmh— Ah, M-Myd-ei…!” his partner moans, inner walls twitching around him, “S-So good… feels so good…!”

“Louder,” Mydei commands, pace picking up – his hips snap against Phainon's, driving him up the wall with every thrust. The Deliverer's eyes roll back, curses and prayer alike rolling off his stuck out tongue. “Louder!”

Mydei slams inside, and Phainon *screams.* Tears sprout from his eyes and drool from his mouth, his hole convulsing around Mydei. “Mmh–! Ah, ahn… M-Myd– Ah! Mm… more! More, fuck m-me hard-er!”

The kremnoan obliges. Thrusts into Phainon with speed and might, mind drowning in a cacophony of slapping noises and moans that follow the cadence of his hips. It's so hot and wet inside it feels like his cock is

melting, like he's fusing together with Phainon, like he's getting closer, closer, *so close.*

“Yes, yes, hnnh, th-there, fuck!” his partner cries out, his voice cracking, “Mm– ‘M gonna– Gonna cum! Mydei… ah, M-Mydei… cumming… c-cumminnng…!”

Phainon’s walls convulse around him, shooting electric sparks that catch on his gut and leave him disoriented – he thrusts blindly, without rhythm, cock throbbing and muscles clenching with an orgasm that makes him breathless. He pushes deep inside and stays still whille pumping his load, teeth gritted into a lustful snarl.

While his body recovers, he finds himself breathing heavily into the crook of Phainon's neck, holding up his weight by sheer force of will – his limbs feel like jelly.

“My *God,”* Phainon breathes out, “I’m all sticky and gross! And here I thought showers were supposed to make one clean.”

It's only later that day that Mydei finally gets into the mindset to message Aglaea about Phainon's partial recovery.

He pulls out his phone while they’re together on the couch, Deliverer crashed out on his lap after playing with his hair, like they’ve been doing daily ever since the start of this arrangement. Mydei briefly explains the situation to Aglaea via text and returns his attention to the slumbering body in his arms.

Phainon looks so peaceful. *Angelic.* His ribs rise and fall slow and steady, legs outstretched, thighs showing subtle signs of Mydei's manhandling in reds and pinks. The kremnoan moves his fingers through that soft snowy hair and watches the shiny strands fall over Phainon's cheek, causing his narrow nose to scrunch up.

“I hate how adorable you are,” he mutters to himself as his teleslate vibrates beside him. He reaches for it and, unsurprisingly, Aglaea has already responded.

> **Miss Aglaea:** Really? That's great news. [audio transcript]

> **Miss Aglaea:** He may be able to safely function on his own if he regains his sight before his hearing. What do you plan on doing if that happens? [audio transcript]

> **You:** Of course I'll stay with h|

Mydei stares at the blinking slash while Phainon's singing – now humming – functions as white noise. The kremnoan deletes character by character that he's typed, pauses for a while, and finally decides on a proper reply.

You: That's not for me to decide. I will respect his wishes.

Even if they're against mine, is left unsaid.

Mydei is deeply concentrated on cleaning, so much so that he only realizes Phainon is around when the broom he's using hits the poor thing on the shin. Phainon crouches with a yelp, hands rubbing the injured bone. “Ow! *Bitch*– fuck!” he barks, grimacing, “Did I hit the goddamned table again?! It's the third time already!”

Mydei crouches beside him and places an apologetic kiss to his forehead – “I'm sorry. Didn't see you there.”

Phainon doesn't reply to his words, but does respond to his action – tilts his head up to snatch another kiss, hands leaving his ankle to cup Mydei's face. The Deliverer pulls away with a curious look to his face, fingertips carefully moving towards the nape of Mydei's neck.

“You tied up your hair,” he comments in awe, “Too bad I can't see it. You must look so handsome.”

Mydei can't help the heat that crawls up his neck to settle on his cheeks, or the mad sprint of his heart. Before he gives himself away by suffocating Phainon with kisses, he instead takes his partner by the waist and bridal carries him to the couch so he can finish cleaning.

“By the gods, Mydei, your tits are *huge.*”

Mydei's eyes twitches. That *feels* like a compliment, especially with Phainon fondling his chest so fervently. He should've known they would get hot and bothered bathing together – hell; he was already hard *before* Phainon got on all four on the tub and started biting and squeezing his pectorals.

“Mmh… I wanna eat them,” his partner mumbles.

His tongue laps over Mydei's nipple, flicking it, before rolling around it. He takes the nub into his mouth and gives it a few sucks before using his teeth in provocation, fingers abusing the other side. Phainon's round, milky ass rises just above the water, lightly swaying, the surface of the bath rippling as he jerks off underwater. He eventually stops, head lifting off Mydei's pectorals to show dazed eyes, flushed cheeks, reddish lips.

“Mm… ah… M-Mydei… fuck me?” he pleads, hands roaming down the kremnoan's torso until they reach the throbbing erection between his legs;

he gives it a few tentative pumps. “So big. Fuck; I want it so bad…!”

The kremnoan sucks in air through gritted teeth, index finger hooking under Phainon's choker and tugging on it to pull him closer.

“As you wish.”

“You're such a great wife. Best wife. Yes, you are.”

Mydei isn't quite sure if his eye is just twitching or if he's having an aneurysm.

Phainon's behind him, fondling his chest – *again* – while resting his chin on Mydei's shoulder. The kremnoan, on the other hand, is trying his best to do the dishes with a clingy puppy attached, and *just barely* succeeding.

“I promise I'll be a good husband, mhm,” the Deliverer whispers, placing small, tender kisses on his neck and shoulder while closing his arms around Mydei's waist. “Just wait ‘til I get better. I'll take care of you too.”

Mydei bites the inside of his cheek, eyebrows drawing together in concentration as he attempts not to self combust. He fears he may be having an *actual* cardiac issue, because his chest physically hurts with how strongly his heart is beating. Hopefully it won't kill him.

“Mm, this is perfect! You *have* to teach me how to cook someday. Maybe I'll do it for you too,” a happy Phainon offers, smiling round, “In just an apron. Aaand the meal will be *me.*”

“Hmph. I'll hold you to your word,” Mydei replies with a smirk, helping Phainon eat more stew while it's still steaming.

Sleep. Mydei just wants to sleep. The *I-have-no-idea-what-time-it-is* Deliverer, though, thinks it's a good idea to lay his head on the kremnoan's shoulder, a fingertip drawing circles on his chest and—

“Mydei, would you still love me if I were a worm?”

Mydei glares at the ceiling and attempts to summon forth that potential cardiac arrest to kill him.

It doesn't work.

“...maybe. You *are* a softie,” Phainon eventually responds to himself, “But I bet you wouldn’t *fuck* a worm.”

“Thanatos,” the kremnoan exhales, “Why hast thou forsaken me?”

It's so bright when he opens his eyes that he has to close them again. Even through his eyelids, light filters through and causes what remains of his sleepiness to evaporate. Grumbling, limbs stretching and his jaw popping with a big yawn, Phainon blinks a few times and finally manages to keep his eyelids open.

“Mydei…”

Phainon uses the back of his fingers to tuck some strawberry blonde locks behind Mydei's ear, and runs his gaze over his serene sleeping face. A smile tugs on the Deliverer's lips and he inches closer to lightly press them against Mydei's own. The kremnoan nods, still sleeping—

“Huh.”

He stops moving. Looks around – *looks* – and sees? *He sees.* He sees!

“Mydei! Mydei, wake up! I can see you!” he exclaims, sitting up in a jolt and shaking his partner awake. The whirlpool of emotions and shapes and colors leaves him breathless, his fingertips trembling and prickling as he brings them to his face – and *sees* them – and slides them down his face. He hiccups out little sobs, clearing his sight from the blurriness of tears by blinking quickly and rubbing his eyes. They sting. He sees. *He isn't dreaming.*

Warm hands cover his own. He glances at a surprised Mydei with messy bed hair, his rosy lips moving even though no sound reaches Phainon's ears. *“I can't hear you yet… but I can see you,”* he whispers brokenly, lips trembling, sobs bubbling up his chest as he squeezes Mydei's hands around his face, pressing kisses to their palms, *“I can see you again.”*

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> As usual, thank you all SSSSSSSO MUCH for the support!! I'm genuinely thankful and so happy that you're all liking this!! It's a passion project that I can't stop thinking about, haha.

Mydei. He's beautiful – broad shoulders, angular face. Ah, There's the bed. The sheets… blue. White walls, golden mirror, silky white curtains blowing in the breeze. Sunlight filters through. Pink camellias on the nightstand. Mydei – his eyes are incandescent, his skin deliciously tanned. Red ink swirls and curls over muscles. Electricity zaps through Phainon's ocular nerves; he sees stars. His head hurts. The window, the sky outside, *Mydei,* his lips are moving, so rosy, so *beautiful*, *too much.*

It's only after Mydei takes him into an embrace and rubs soothing circles on his back that Phainon notices he's been hyperventilating, whole body trembling, his heart rhythm an aching mess. He takes deep breaths, wraps his arms around Mydei's neck and closes his eyes; they feel cold and dry. He hadn't been blinking.

He retreats, momentarily, into what's become his unexpected comfort zone – darkness. Surrounded only by Mydei's warmth and scent, soft hair tickling his nose, a calloused hand caressing his back, it's easy to regain control. His partner's chest vibrates like he's saying something – possibly words of comfort; *‘take it slow’, ‘I’m right here'.*

It takes him a while to calm down, and he only succeeds because of Mydei's seemingly infinite patience – he doesn't pull away until Phainon does, and stays close even after, unmoving save for blinking. He allows Phainon's

fingertips to glide over his jaw, his chin, his lips, to curl around his hair. The Deliverer takes note of all his facial features as if it's the first time he's seeing Mydei – his eyebrows, the shape of his nose, his lips, the red ink underneath his eye, the length of his eyelashes, the shadows his hair casts over his cheeks. His mouth moves, showing glimpses of white teeth and a pink tongue.

Phainon cocks his head to the side, gaze returning to Mydei's eyes. His confusion must've shown quite clearly, because the kremnoan leans back, reaching for his teleslate on the nightstand, types into it and shows Phainon the screen:

[You can't hear me?]

Sighing, Phainon shakes his head and takes Mydei's device to write back to him:

[No! I was hoping I would. ｡:　(;´∩`;)　:｡]

Mydei looks at him… *weird.* He rubs the back of his head, avoiding eye contact, before taking back the device:

[It's ok. You don't have to type; I can hear you just fine]

The Deliverer releases a breath of relief, leaning back on his arms. *“Oh thank the heavens; that makes things— Wait, you can what?!”* Phainon sits upright again, an accusatory finger jabbing into Mydei's chest. It's partially just to have an excuse to poke those meaty buns, but he digresses. *“Since when?!”*

[A few days now]

Phainon feels the blood draining from his face… and then returning with a passion, because his cheeks *burn.* He lightly slaps Mydei on the shoulder to display his indignation, a scowl pulling on his hips. *“And you didn't even bother warning me about it?! No, no,”* Phainon interrupts the kremnoan as he's about to type something into his teleslate, *“Don't go saying you couldn't. I'm so embarrassed I wanna die either way.”*

[Are you sure you don't want to become a worm instead?] Mydei provokes with a smirk.

“You are,” Phainon hisses, *“Despicable.”*

[You said something very different when we were fu—]

Phainon doesn't finish reading, instead groaning loudly and smacking both hands across his face to hide its *certain* redness from Mydei. *“This is the worst. I can't believe my lack of luck.”*

Mydei carefully takes Phainon's hands and kisses his fingertips, later repeating the motion to his lips. Their cheeks brush warmly together as he slowly retreats. The next time he pulls up his teleslate, it reads – [It wasn't my intention to upset you. I'm sorry]

"...no; it's okay. Sorry for overreacting. At least…" Phainon makes a pause, hesitant, caressing Mydei's face with the back of his fingers. *"You're the first thing I saw when I opened my eyes. I'm glad,"* he chuckles, *"I was afraid I'd get my vision back in front of the dirty dishes."*

A smile lights up Mydei's complexion. It's small but seems heartfelt, genuine, and it's positively breathtaking – it makes Phainon feel special. The crown prince of Castrum Kremnos is smiling on *his* bed, wearing nothing but underwear, with the messiest bed hair, and there's the perfect imprint of *his* teeth on that beautifully tanned neck, along with red and purple hickeys that *he* left all the way down to the chest.

Even if just for a short moment, he's *claimed* Mydei.

Phainon looks away with his face warm, unable to cope with how high his heart loops around itself, the back of his hand to his mouth. *I love him so much; this is bad, I'm so screwed.*

Mydei taps his shoulder, asking for attention, and shows his screen – [What do you want to do now?]

He knows he wants to *not* think about all the embarrassing things the kremnoan may or may not have heard him say, and doesn't want to bring any more attention to that. As he decides his next move, his eyes roam over Mydei's form in a way he never could before – he traces every arch of muscle with his gaze, salivates at the dark rosy hue of his nipples, sighs at the inviting dip of his sternum, bites his lip at the arch of Mydei’s hipbones and the path it creates to his groin.

“Oh, I know.”

Phainon pushes Mydei onto the bed and straddles him, the curve of his ass right over the kremnoan's dick, and grins, licking his lips – *“I want to see what kind of face you make when you're cumming.”*

Red crawls up a surprised Mydei's neck to settle on his cheeks, twitching beneath Phainon. He takes his teleslate and Phainon sees, upside down, that he's typing *[That's not what I]* but doesn't finish the sentence. Instead, he shakes his head and types, with a smirk, [Then make me.] with his free hand burning a path up Phainon's thigh.

“Is that an order, Prince Mydeimos?”

[It's a challenge, Deliverer.]

The sky is absolutely beautiful – a vivid blue, peppered with a few white clouds and a colorful rainbow. Phainon smiles at the view from his veranda, arms crossed over the rail as he leans against it. He sees, from his peripheral vision, as Mydei approaches and rests beside him, though with his back to the horizon, and offers him a steaming mug.

Phainon takes a quick glance at the kremnoan before accepting – he's tied up his hair and has nothing but a towel wrapped low around his hips. *"Are you trying to seduce me?"* the Deliverer asks with a quirking eyebrow, reaching for the mug and humming in satisfaction at the swirled cream on top of what he decides, through smell, is coffee.

Mydei lifts up his teleslate: [I already have.]

"Cocky prince," Phainon scoffs, but inwardly agrees. He takes a few sips of his coffee and watches Mydei do the same, though he feels the silence around them is different than usual. It feels… *heavy.* Maybe it's because he can see now? Mydei seems to be deep in thought. Has he been like this all the time? Maybe he isn't as comfortable with this situation as Phainon thought.

"...hey," the Deliverer calls out softly, *"Something wrong?"*

Mydei looks at him with surprise – maybe he hadn't noticed he was so engrossed in his own thoughts? The kremnoan shakes his head and sets down his mug, quickly typing into his device - [It's nothing. Worried?]

“Me? Worried about you?” Phainon snorts, yet feels it in real time as his face warms up. He hides it behind his mug. *“...yeah.”*

Mydei takes the item from his hand and sets it down beside his own, before carefully turning Phainon around by the shoulder and moving in close, heat radiating off his body as he presses it against the Deliverer's. He teases Phainon’s lips with his own, their noses brushing against each other, hands entwining on the marble rail. Mydei whispers something unintelligible against his mouth before finally taking it into a kiss; Phainon's eyes immediately close, heart fluttering in his chest.

Despite the bitterness of coffee, it's a sweet kiss – deep and slow, tongues lapping firmly at each other, bodies sharing warmth. They stare into each other's eyes for a while after parting, like there's things left undaid, and it makes Phainon suspect the kremnoan even more.

Maybe he's tired of doing everything for Phainon. Maybe he's just tired *overall*, or stressed, or homesick, or in a bad mood; perhaps all of those together. Whatever the case, Phainon decides to do something to at least *alleviate* Mydei's stress.

“H-How am I– supposed to…!”

Mydei curls his toes inside and his fingers around Phainon's hair; the Deliverer chuckles around his cock and slides all the way out, flashing him a smile as his tongue flicks out to lap at the head. He sucks his way in again, lips curling around the base as he gives it a harsh suck, and Mydei jerks his hips forward; he holds the sink behind him and knocks the pineapple he'd been cutting into the sink.

“Phainon!”

The Deliverer seems to be *more* inclined to continue abusing Mydei's cock than the opposite – he slides in and out, lips closed tight around the flushed length, glossy eyes locked to Mydei's. He moans lustfully, throat vibrating, saliva and precum momentarily connecting the tip of his tongue to the kremnoan's cock as he pulls away with a hum. He presses the length to his cheek, nuzzling with his eyes mischievously slanted.

“Mmh, come on,” Phainon smiles, Mydei's veiny cock throbbing against his face as he gives it a leisurely lick, “Stop holding back… fuck my mouth, Mydei. You know I like it rough.”

Mydei cracks him a lustful snarl. Grabs him by the hair with both hands and guides that lustful mouth to his erection, pushing it in with ease; Phainon rolls his tongue around it as it breaches his throat and sheathes entirely.

“You're unbelievable,” Mydei accuses as he's establishing a slow pace, pulling all the way out before watching his thick length go back into Phainon, “I had a knife… in my hand…!”

Not that the Deliverer seemed to care. He just turned Mydei around against the sink, kissed him breathless and knelt down to suck him off – the possibility of getting accidentally stabbed was either an afterthought… or an *incentive.*

The kremnoan groans as he's picking up the pace, grip firm on Phainon's locks, hips thrusting without mercy; tears sprout from Phainon's eyes as they roll back, moans vibrate into Mydei's cock. He sees the Deliverer's hand slipping into his own pants and moving rapidly; it only causes him to be harsher – he fucks Phainon's mouth with gusto, choking noises, slaps and wet *schlops* creating a lewd symphony.

Mydei's already nearing the edge when he catches Phainon's body quaking with pleasure, tears and cum dripping to the floor. The sight tips him over the edge – his orgasm is sudden and unexpected, leaving his knees weak, eyes shutting closed and teeth clenching as he shoots into the heat of Phainon's mouth and throat.

He pulls away only to slide down to the floor, panting loudly, eyelids heavy. He watches Phainon's throat bobbing as he swallows, wiping drool and who knows what else from his chin with the back of his hand. He looks positively fucked up, yet still smiles with satisfaction – “Mmh! Wonderful meal. Can't wait for dessert.”

Mydei laughs huskily, the back of his hand in front of his face to hide both his blush and his mirth. The kneeling Phainon sits back on his legs, head lightly cocking to the side, and though his face is still red from their… *activities,* Mydei has the feeling it's also because of something else. There's a shy, timid quality to the way Phainon looks at him.

“Are you, uh…” He breaks eye contact for a moment, as if mulling over his words, “Feeling a little bit better? Less stressed, maybe?”

Mydei feels his heart sinking. Something must've shown on his face, because Phainon immediately trips all over his words, stammering so terribly he's barely comprehensible. He keeps his lower lip sucked into his mouth and eyebrows drawn together; his hands curl into fists over his thighs. He suddenly shakes his head and smiles apologetically – “...no, nevermind! I'm just being silly. Need any help with that pineapple?”

Even though they're doing something they've grown accustomed to – cuddling on the couch – Phainon can't help but feel discomfort. Mydei's been looking at him weird all day, and though they've been *doing* intimate things, it feels as if they aren't *being* as intimate, like there's something invisible between them.

Maybe Phainon said something that Mydei didn't like these past few days? But he's spent *hours* now going through every word that left his mouth, and nothing seems to fit the criteria to make Mydei upset. Maybe… he's been able to talk for longer than he thinks, and accidentally confessed? But then why would everything be normal until Phainon regained his sight?

He exhales a heavy, tired sigh over Mydei's chest and sits up. Straddling the kremnoan and looking at his curious face, Phainon's resolve falters. *"You, uh. You're silent. Haha. You know, even though I wouldn't be able to hear you anyway, since…"* he gesticulates towards his ears and looks away in shame – stupid. *Stupid.*

Mydei taps his shoulder to gain his attention and shows his screen:
[Something wrong? You're acting weird]

Phainon resists the urge to frown, but he's not sure how well he succeeds… or doesn't. *"I… was hoping you would tell me. You're the one acting weird,"* he corrects. *"Are you choosing to keep a stick up your ass? You can always use my dick instead."*

The Deliverer mentally punches himself, *hard,* on the brain. He's rushing and tumbling over his words, speaking in riddles, acting like a child. He *wants* to be direct and ask Mydei outright if he's committed some mistake, if the kremnoan is angry, *anything* better than what he's doing, but the knot in his throat won't let him, *anxiety* won't let him. He curls his hands so it doesn't show that he's trembling.

Mydei doesn't respond. He looks away, seemingly deep in thought like he's been so many times that day. Phainon feels a pit in his stomach and guilt, so much guilt, *fucking fix it, Phainon, this is your fault.*

"…oh man, that joke did not land the way I intended! Hahaha!"

The kremnoan stares at him for a while, expression unreadable but charged with *something*, and begins typing. Every tap of his fingers accelerates the countdown to a bomb about to go off in Phainon's chest. It finally explodes when he looks at the words on the screen:

[Should I leave?]

Phainon's blood runs cold. He gets off the couch even though it feels like his legs won't hold his weight and that he'll faint any second now for not being able to breathe. Mydei sits up but doesn't move further, likely waiting for an answer.

"I… I'm sorry," Phainon blabbers out, barely thinking about his words, *"I said something I shouldn't, right? Or maybe—"*

[Phainon, that's not it] Mydei interrupts with his teleslate. The Deliverer shakes his head in denial.

"I'm beyond thankful for everything you did for me. I really am," Phainon assures, *"You were so good to me… it must've been exhausting. I'm so sorry I have nothing to offer you in return. But if that counts for something, you can have my body anytime—"*

[Phainon, stop!] Mydei insists, standing up with a frown. He sighs, a hand to his face. He's so visibly frustrated it makes Phainon want to vomit. He can't stop his words from tumbling out when Mydei begins typing again – *"Mydei… do you want to leave?"*

The kremnoan stops typing, looks at him. Deletes. Types again.

[No]

“Then why…” Phainon takes a few breaths, unable to conjure up what he really means. He resigns to his fate instead, regretful of his outburst. *“It's okay, sorry for acting up like that. You just… caught me by surprise,”* he laughs humorlessly, but refusing to make eye contact, *“I’ll help you gather your things—”*

Mydei grabs his shoulder. He silently mouths Phainon's name before, apparently, remembering that he can't be heard; he then types into his device.

[I do want to stay, but I don't want to step over your boundaries.]

“There's no boundaries,” Phainon corrects, then adds in a smaller voice, *“Not with you.”*

Mydei's gaze softens. He doesn't type for a while, only staring into Phainon's eyes like there's something he's searching for inside them. Soon enough, though, he has more to say – [I'm glad. However…]

[People in Okhema are talking about us.]

It's Phainon's turn to frown. *“Talking what?”*

After a few taps into his teleslate, Mydei offers it to Phainon. Greeting him on the screen is a news article with a picture of the two of them, nearly kissing on their picnic, with a scandalous headline that only a very inspired Verax Leo could have come up with. Phainon has mixed feelings reading the article – what's wrong with it? What's making Mydei upset about it?

“What, you don't want people to think we're together?” the Deliverer suggests even though the idea hurts as much as a stab to the chest, faking a mocking smile, *“We can just tell them the truth.”*

[It's not that easy, Phainon. Honestly, that's not even the problem]

“Then, pray tell, what is the problem? Mydei, you…” Phainon stammers, *“You're meant to be a king. Is that why? Is it because I'm a man? Am I shaming you, ruining your reputation?”*

[That has nothing to do with it! Are you even listening to yourself?!]

“No!” the Deliverer roars, tears forming behind his eyelids, *“I fucking can't! See, that's why this whole torment started in the first place! I wanted this! I wanted not to hear you, or see you, or even talk to you, because you*

always…!” Phainon stops himself mid sentence, attempting to breathe but failing, his heart cracking right in the middle as he grabs at his chest, *“I’m so affected by everything you do… every fucking breath you take. Do you have any idea how maddening this is?!”*

Trying to impress him, trying to beat him; feeling simultaneously strong and oh so weak when by his side. *Compliment me, notice me, like me, stay with me.* Phainon can't even begin to point out all of the infinite pieces of the puzzle his mind has made out of Mydei; all he knows is that they're so many that they crawl all over each other and cut into whatever's left inside of Phainon's chest to fit in there.

Mydei's eyes gloss over, his lips pursed tight. His arm falls beside his body and he mouths a quiet *“I'm sorry”*.

Phainon's entire structure quakes. He takes too many breaths but they're all insufficient; his chest hurts and feels like it's caving inside – a tomb for his heart. *“If you're really sorry, you're going to cut the crap and tell me exactly what's happening,”* he presses, *“Why are you so worried about all these things?! Why are we even having this conversation?!”*

“Because I fell in love with you!” Mydei cries out.

Phainon hears everything.

Every syllable, every consonant and vowel, the cadence of Mydei's baritone, the way his voice cracks. He hears the sound of his own heartbeats

as they rise to his throat, and the tempest of blood rushing to his skull. He drops to his knees, and covers his face with both trembling hands, fingernails digging into his skin.

“...Mydei…!”

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

AND WE'RE HERE! So sorry that this took so long to update; IRL has been SOMETHING lately.

It's been a pleasure to write this story! Thank you to everyone who spared some time to read this, and to Kourt for being so patient with me I'M SORRY YOU'RE AN ANGEL AND ILY.

I find endings remarkably difficult to write, so here's hoping this is not too bad!

Toot-toot! :D

The sound of his breaths blowing at his palms emulates that of a hurricane, accompanied by the thunderous beats of his pulse in his ears. Everything else is drowned, including his sense of self – all that's left is a barely coherent, rewinding mantra of *he loves me, he loves me, he loves me* that wraps all around him like a serpent and constricts *tight.* Phainon produces *something* from the back of his throat – a groan, a scream, a roar, a cry; he lacks the means to categorize that strangled, visceral noise.

He removes his face from behind his trembling hands to glare at Mydei with blurry eyes, feeling the distinctive heat of tears rolling down his cheeks as he blinks, copper on his tongue as he bites into his quivering lip. "You…!" he sobs, pointing an accusing finger at his visibly confused partner, "How *dare* you!"

"I… what?"

Phainon proceeds to show Mydei why he's a swordsman and not a gunslinger by taking his flipflop, flinging it at the kremnoan and missing by a *lot* of inches. “I loved you first!”

Amidst his own sobs and confused, *embarrassed* groans, Phainon hears a hearty laugh. He hides his burning face into his hands again, whole body quaking with the onslaught of sensations both physical and emotional that explode inside him one after the other, as if his very soul suddenly went supernova.

The warmth of Mydei’s body radiates into him and stabilizes the absolute *mess* he’s become when the kremnoan pulls him into his lap, arms carefully wrapping around him. Phainon doesn’t risk looking at his face yet, unwilling to show his own and the particular shade of red his cheeks have *definitely* taken on, instead allowing himself time to recover. Mydei shows, once again, his unwavering patience by waiting until the Deliverer is comfortable enough to come out of hiding – until he takes a peek, first, through his parted fingers, then finally slides them away.

Mydei’s expression is serene enough that it makes Phainon melt on his lap – his irises shine brighter than honey as the back of his fingers brush against the Deliverer’s cheeks, lips curved softly upwards with a smile that briefly shows teeth as he murmurs in the sweetest voice, “My sweet crybaby.”

“Ugh,” Phainon fakes a grimace that *positively* doesn’t hide how big he’s smiling, “I really hope you can come up with a better pet name.” With a sigh of relief, Phainon begins his comfort activity of toying with Mydei’s braid; the fibers are soft against his fingertips, tickling them as he follows their length. “I can't believe this entire sensory saga could have been avoided. I could have confessed *ages* ago,” he muses out loud.

“I could say the same,” Mydei assures, taking Phainon’s hand to place a kiss to his fingers, “Don't blame yourself.”

“Nuh uh, I don't want to blame *you*, I want to blame *me.*”

“How about we split the guilt evenly?” the kremnoan suggests with something bashful about his expression, blushing the lightest rosy pink, “Like a good couple would do.”

Phainon has to immediately bury his face on the crook of Mydei’s neck to protect the world – and his *dignity* – from the fire burning off his cheeks. He smiles so big and so heartful that a little sob hiccups its way up his chest; he didn’t think happiness was a tangible thing, but he definitely feels it *physically* in every fiber of his being, tiny sparks that crackle bright in every atom and rise goosebumps on his skin.

Unable to contain his mirth, Phainon pulls away only enough to give Mydei a toothy grin, foreheads resting together. “You *do* have a bigger chest, so maybe it's a *little bit* more your fault than mine,” he teases, sliding a fingertip provocatively down his partner's sternum.

“Well, you win in the butt department, so I would say we're even,” the kremnoan retorts, nails grazing down Phainon’s spine to steal a shiver and a strangled little whine.

“...we should compare our bodies again,” the Deliverer breathes out, skin rippling with excited chills, “Just to make sure.”

“Mm… only if I can check inside you,” Mydei whispers hotly into his ear, one hand firmly cupping his ass, his deep baritone making Phainon’s bones rattle.

From there, it’s all a daze – Phainon’s naked back hits the mattress, and he’s not even sure when or *how* he’s gotten rid of his clothes. Mydei crawls over him like a hungry lion, devours his mouth with tongue and teeth and *passion,* feels his body with a heavy grip, and Phainon is a most willing prey. His hands tremble as his palm slides over every curve of taut muscle on his partner’s shoulders and chest, nipples briefly catching between his fingers, velvety skin burning under his touch.

Mydei’s rock hard cock leaks as Phainon wraps his fingers around it; the kremnoan’s teeth show in a snarl as he deeply groans with pleasure, and that guttural sound alone nearly makes Phainon shoot his load – he clamps his thighs together, gut tight, his own length throbbing over his stomach. He wants to close his eyes but forces them to stay open to watch the sweat glistening over Mydei’s muscular body, the subtle signs of bliss showing on his expression as he bucks into the Deliverer’s hand, his pupils swallowing the honey golden of his irises.

Phainon feels drunk. Mydei’s scent inebriates him, his voice cradles him as if it has a body of its own; he’s ensnared by the sight of strawberry blond locks getting messier and damper with every stroke, every kiss, every moan, his braid coming undone, dark, lustful shadows casting over his face. Phainon locks his arms around Mydei’s neck and captures his mouth again, breaths coming out as lustful hiccups until the kremnoan purposely sucks

his breath away and leaves him to sharply arch his spine, eyes and head rolling back.

Phainon's hole twitches as his partner rubs it with lubricated fingers; he whimpers brokenly as the digits penetrate him and spread apart, curling upwards on the way back to stimulate his prostate. Little tears of pleasure catch on his eyelashes, blurring his sight of Mydei as he pulls away from the kiss, golden eyes locked to the Deliverer's face as his fingers ram into him, slaps and *shlops* and his own voice pitifully chanting *Mydei, Mydei, Mydei* fill his ears in a lustful symphony.

Precum pools on his navel, sweat rolls down his thighs, tears slide hotly down his face towards his scalp; he blinks away drop after crystalline drop to keep watching Mydei, the crease of concentration in his eyebrows, his parted lips spilling out hot breaths, his chest heaving and biceps straining as he fucks the soul out of Phainon with his fingers. The Deliverer loses it before he's even able to announce it – hot jolts coil in his gut, his ass *itches* with pleasure and a breath locks on his throat as he pushes his hips off the bed and *convulses,* tongue rolling out with a silent scream, fingers digging into the mattress, cum landing heavily on his abdomen and chest.

He falls back with a whimper, spasms overtaking his muscles as he attempts to regain his breathing amidst hiccups and sobs. Mydei chuckles lustfully, one hand cradling Phainon's face; he licks the Deliverer's tears from his cheeks all the way to his eyelashes, thumb rubbing circles on his jaw. "Crybaby," he provokes, "You're adorable."

The very next second, Phainon flips them over to have Mydei sprawled on the bed beneath him. The look of surprise on the kremnoan's face quickly switches to an amused one, a cocky smirk playing by his lips. "And you're

terrible," Phainon lies, lining up the head of Mydei's cock with his abused entrance, "Absolutely vile."

"Is that why you fell for me?"

"No. It's why I'm going to shut you up like *this,"* the Deliverer announces, and slams *down,* all the way, all at once. He resists the urge to throw his head back in bliss as his walls are stretched to accommodate Mydei's girth, a curt laugh bubbling out of his core as his partner visibly loses his mind beneath him, back arching off the bed, hands blindly reaching for Phainon's thighs and curses spilling out of his lips – " Fucking shit, *fuck!"* followed by unrecognizable words that he can only guess have a meaning in ancient kremnoan.

Phainon *refuses* to give him time to recompose – rides him fast and hard, cock dripping onto Mydei's stomach as he bounces, fingers sinking into those meaty pectorals to knead and grab and *mistreat.* His partner's fingernails drive into his thighs, hips pushing up to meet him halfway, moans becoming more incoherent, cock scratching Phainon's walls *so good* and reaching him *so deep* it makes him see stars.

"M-Myd— Mydei," he exhales, "Ah– S-So good…! Alm… ost… mmh…!"

The kremnoan groans deeply in response, hand moving to Phainon's erection to pump it with tight, messy strokes; he thrusts upwards more harshly, the impact of them slamming against each other sending shockwaves into the Deliverer's bones and causing the bed to rattle beneath

them. “Phainon…!” his partner cries out, his rhythm uncertain but relentlessly fast, “I’m… I’m cumming…! Hnnh—!”

Phainon’s eyes roll back, his frame shaking and muscles clamping to the verge of collapse as he tightens his jaw and screams from behind gritted teeth. His orgasm is so intense it lights up liquid fire under his skin, cock pulsating *hard* with every burst of semen he shoots over Mydei’s chest. His partner’s hips push up and stay flush against Phainon’s ass, girth throbbing so deep inside him he feels it in his stomach.

His skin prickles with the blissful high. His muscles spasm, his throat makes an ungodly sound against his will; Phainon nearly collapses over Mydei as his limbs become liquid, but continues to prop himself up with both hands on his partner’s chest in an admittedly stubborn attempt to prove his strength and stamina. He does wiggle a little, though, so that Mydei’s softening length slides out of him.

He keeps his eyes closed as he’s recovering from his orgasm, despite his desire to see Mydei’s face as he’s undone – *apprehension.* He can’t tell where it comes from. If it’s because he loves this man so much that it feels like that love will swallow him whole; if it’s because he’s afraid Mydei’s confession was all a dream or hallucination, a prank, pity, *a lie;* or if, on the contrary, it’s because he knows that Mydei’s feelings *are* true.

Inevitably, soon enough, fate will catch up with them and their end will come. Inevitably, one of them will have to watch the other die, or even be the cause of each other’s demise. There will be blood on their last goodbye, and it’s probably not very far away. They won’t age by each other’s side, commemorate anniversaries together, wake up one day and decide to go on a trip, just the two of them, just because they can.

Happily ever after doesn’t exist for them. *Happy now,* maybe.

“Phainon…” Mydei calls him as softly as his husky voice will allow. He sits up with the Deliverer on his lap and tenderly holds his face, thumbs brushing at his wet cheeks.

“I’m not a crybaby,” Phainon preemptively tells him, despite the tears his partner keeps wiping away.

“You’re not. I won't call you that anymore.”

“Good. I’m not even crying right now.”

“Of course.”

“I’m just… sensitive.”

“Mmhm.”

“Because I love you so much,” the Deliverer murmurs, cheeks hot.

“And yet, you still refuse to look at me?”

Phainon purses his lips and slowly opens his eyes, blinking to cast away the stubborn little tears clinging to his eyelashes. Mydei watches him in silence, as if waiting for an explanation whenever Phainon feels like giving one. The Deliverer, however, decides it’s a bad idea to bring up those bad thoughts – at least right now – and, instead, chooses to press a small, apologetic kiss to his partner’s lips. “I’m sorry I screamed at you back there. I said some bad things. It doesn’t justify my behavior, but… I was frustrated, and anxious. Thought you didn’t like me; that you were tired of me. I shouldn’t have let it out on you.”

“If you need me to reassure you of my feelings,” Mydei murmurs as he’s tucking hair behind Phainon’s ear, “I shall do it, however many times it takes. It will be my pleasure.”

The Deliverer opens up a round little smile, head tilting to the side – “Does that mean you accept my apology?”

“Of course. *However,”* Mydei grimaces, “Only if you agree to clean up *right now.* We’re both filthy; it’s disgusting.”

“Oh? You don’t like cum dribbling all over your royal balls, Your Highness?” Phainon provokes, wiggling on his partner’s lap.

Contrary to his expectations, Mydei laughs. There’s warmth on the curve of his lips and in his eyes, a peaceful happiness drawn in the details of his expression even as he shakes his head, blond strands following the movement. “Now *that's* the brain cell I fell in love with. Please take good care of it, seeing as it's the only one you have.”

Faking a scowl, Phainon crosses his arms over his chest. “That wasn't very *wifely* of you, mister,” he accuses, “My brain cell is *your* responsibility from now on.”

Mydei watches him for a moment, silent, but amused. “Because we're a couple,” he says tentatively, almost hesitantly, as if unsure whether his logic is sound.

“Yeah,” Phainon nods, his face warm, “We are.”

They spend a moment staring into each other’s eyes as the weight of that new label settles into place, bashful smiles forming on each of their lips. Mydei eventually helps them both off the bed, taking him bridal style in his arms and carrying him towards the bathroom. “While we’re busy cleaning up,” he begins in an inquiring, but quite sweet tone, “Why don’t you tell me more about that egregious claim of loving me first?”

“Oh, that? It’s a *long* story, honeybuns.”

“Honeyb—” Mydei interrupts himself with a groan; he quickly shakes off his grimace. “Go on, humor me. We have some time to spare until the end

of the world anyway.”

Phainon chuckles, preparing his best *storytelling* voice, “Once upon a time, I met a kremnoan prince…”

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End Notes

If you've read this far, thank you so damn much!! ≻✿ ⁰ o ⁰ ✿≺

Any feedback is INFINITELY appreciated! I can't always reply to comments, but will still try my best.

Toot-toot!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!